

CCI'S 1ST CHAIRMAN DHANENDRA KUMAR

Retd IAS officer dies in Hauz Khas house blaze

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Former bureaucrat and the first chairman of the Competition Commission of India (CCI), Dhanendra Kumar, died after a fire, suspected to have been triggered by a blast in an air-conditioning unit, ripped through his residence in Delhi's Hauz Khas, police said on Thursday.

His son was injured in the incident and is undergoing treatment. Kumar (80), a 1968-batch IAS officer of the Haryana cadre, also represented India at the World Bank as an Executive Director.

According to Delhi Fire Services officials, a call regarding the blaze at a house in Hauz Khas Enclave was received at 11.24 pm on Wednesday, following which two fire tenders, including a water bowser, were rushed to the spot.

The fire, which was brought



under control around 12.20 am, engulfed domestic articles on the ground floor and wooden windows on the first floor of the ground-plus-two-storey building, officials said.

Before fire personnel reached the spot, two injured people had already been shifted to the AIIMS Trauma Centre by PCR staff and members of the public. Deputy Commissioner of Police (South) Anant Mittal said Kumar succumbed to smoke inhalation during treatment.

The police said Kumar's son sustained injuries in the

fire and remains under treatment. His condition is stated to be out of danger.

Preliminary inquiry suggested the blaze may have been caused by a blast in the indoor unit of an air-conditioner installed inside the house, officials said. At the time of the incident, five people, including family members and domestic staff, were present inside the residence.

A crime team inspected the spot, while an electrical inspection is underway to ascertain the exact cause of the fire. Statements of eyewitnesses have been recorded, and no foul play is suspected so far, police said.

Kumar held several key administrative positions during his career, including Chairman and Managing Director of the Haryana State Industrial Development Corporation (HSIDC) and Principal Secretary to the Haryana chief minister.

Two octogenarian women found dead inside New Rajinder Ngr residence, no foul play suspected yet

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: Two elderly women were found dead inside their house in central Delhi's New Rajinder Nagar on Thursday morning after neighbours and domestic staff noticed a strong foul smell coming from the premises, police said.

According to police, a PCR call was received at New Rajinder Nagar Police Station around 10.30 am from a maid employed to clean the porch area of the house. She informed police that all doors of the single-storey residence were locked and a foul smell was emanating from inside.



A police team reached the spot and entered the house, where the two women were found unconscious in one of the rooms. One body was lying on the bed, while the other was found on the floor.

CLOSER LOOK

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» The Crime Team and Forensic Science Laboratory team inspected the spot, while CAT Ambulance personnel declared both women dead

declared both women dead. Police said no evidence of foul play had emerged so far, though all angles were being examined. The bodies have been sent to RML Hospital for post-mortem examination.

Court convicts youth for murder of class 12 student

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A Delhi court has convicted a youth for stabbing a teenager to death during a quarrel near Govind Puri Metro station in 2023, saying that the testimony of a sole reliable eyewitness was sufficient to prove the case beyond a reasonable doubt.

Additional Sessions Judge Anuj Agrawal was hearing a case against Shiva Chaudhary, accused of murdering Mohan, a 12th class student, who died after being stabbed in the chest during a clash between two groups of students on January 30, 2023.

In an order dated May 26, the court said, "The cumulative effect of the evidence on record clearly establishes that accused Shiva Chaudhary inflicted the fatal stab injury upon the deceased Mohan, and that the said act was done in furtherance of common intention."

The court relied heavily on the testimony of eyewitness Sumit and said that his account of the incident was "detailed, coherent and consistent".

"He has categorically deposed that... co-accused 'AM' (minor) handed over a knife to the present accused Shiva Chaudhary, who thereafter inflicted a stab injury

on the chest of the deceased," the court said.

According to the prosecution, Mohan and his friends were returning from school when they were intercepted by the accused and his associates near a police booth close to Govind Puri Metro station, following an earlier quarrel between the groups.

The court noted that eyewitness Sumit's testimony remained unshaken despite lengthy cross-examination and was corroborated by other evidence on record, including medical evidence and the testimonies of partly hostile witnesses.

The judge said that while other witnesses did not fully support the prosecution's case, portions of their testimonies still established the presence of the accused, Shiva, at the spot, the quarrel between the groups and the handing over of the knife before the stabbing.

The court said the post-mortem conclusively proved death due to a stab injury to the chest, rejecting defence claims of false implication and noting no material contradictions in the star witness's testimony. It held the prosecution had proved guilt beyond reasonable doubt.

Six apprehended for robbing and assaulting man in Capital

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police has arrested four men and apprehended two juveniles for allegedly abducting and robbing a man on Urban Extension Road-II in Outer North Delhi, an official said on Thursday.

According to police, they committed the crime to fund their partying and lavish spending.

The incident happened in the early hours of May 27, when the accused allegedly intercepted the victim's motorcycle near Holambi Khurd, dragged him into a car, assaulted him and robbed him of his mobile phone and motorcycle before abandoning him on the roadside.

According to the police, the victim, Anirudh Tripathi, a resident of Holambi Khurd working at Shahbad Dairy, was returning home when he was robbed.

"Four occupants of the car allegedly overpowered Tripathi and forcibly dragged him inside the vehicle. The accused assaulted him while the car was moving and later dumped him near Hanuman Mandir in Narela before fleeing with his motorcycle and mobile phone," Deputy Commissioner of Police (Outer North) Hareeshwar Swami in a statement said. Police said a PCR call



VICTIM'S ACCOUNT

» According to the police, the victim, identified as Abhinav Tripathi, a resident of Holambi Khurd working at Shahbad Dairy, was returning home when he was robbed

» 'Four occupants of the car allegedly overpowered Tripathi and forcibly dragged him inside the vehicle. The accused assaulted him while the car was moving and later dumped him near Hanuman Mandir in Narela before fleeing with his motorcycle and mobile phone'

regarding the incident was received after the victim's brother, Anirudh Tripathi, informed police about the robbery and kidnapping. A case was registered, and an investigation was launched.

The team analysed CCTV footage from nearby routes and used technical surveillance and local intelligence to identify the suspects. "Our teams identified the accused, following which they were arrested some time after the incident," the DCP said. The accused have been identified as Harsh (21), a resident of Delhi, Ankit (24), Sudhir (28), and Sanket (19), while the two apprehended juveniles

are aged 17, both residents of Haryana's Sonapat.

According to police, Ankit worked as a driver and was previously involved in a criminal case in Haryana. Harsh, a casual labourer, had earlier been booked under the Arms Act in a case registered at Kanjhawala police station in Delhi.

Police recovered the car used in the crime, the robbed motorcycle and the victim's mobile phone.

They further said that an investigation is underway to ascertain whether the gang was involved in other highway robberies in the Delhi-Haryana border region.

Crime Branch takes over probe into Amar Colony teen shooting

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police Crime Branch has taken over the investigation into the shooting of a 17-year-old boy at an eatery in southeast Delhi's Amar Colony, officials said on Thursday.

The teenager, critical after the shooting, continues to battle for life at AIIMS Trauma Centre.

A 16-year-old boy, alleged to be the shooter, was apprehended by police from Okhla in the early hours of Wednesday with an automatic pistol in his possession, officials said.

The police have identified the two more persons, aged 17 and 18, allegedly involved in the incident. Both are residents of Okhla and have criminal backgrounds, sources said. Investigators are probing the background of the apprehended juvenile, a realtor's son, sources added.

The incident took place on Tuesday evening when the victim, Sai Kumar, went to an Amar Colony eatery with a female friend after giving his class 12 exam.

According to the victim's family, a group of three boys allegedly passed some remarks at the girl, leading to a confrontation. They alleged that the accused left the spot before returning moments after with a firearm, and assaulting Sai and shooting him near his temple.

However, the police said the altercation may have started after one of the accused brushed past the victim's chair.

A PCR call regarding the incident was received around 7.54 pm. The injured teenager was rushed to hospital by his friend. Sai is on ventilator support with a bullet lodged in his

brain, family members said.

Police sources said the apprehended juvenile was also involved in another shooting incident reported in Kalkaji last year. He allegedly used to pose as a relative of a politician and move around the Amar Colony area.

Two months ago, a complaint was lodged against him for allegedly misusing the politician's name, sources claimed.

Sai, an only child, lives with his family in South Delhi. His father runs a laundry shop in Chittaranjan Park area while his grandfather operates another shop in South Extension, relatives said. The Crime Branch is examining CCTV footage from the locality and questioning witnesses to establish the exact sequence of events and motive behind the attack. PII

Delhi launches WCD internship framework

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Students pursuing courses such as social work, psychology, law and gender studies will get structured field exposure at child care institutions and welfare centres run by the Delhi government under a new internship and research framework issued by the Women and Child Development Department (WCD).

Under the guidelines, interns and researchers will be engaged in community-based initiatives, flagship welfare schemes and institutional activities aimed at providing practical understanding of grassroots-level social service delivery systems.

The WCD issued detailed norms for internships, academic research, post-doctoral studies and educational visits at its institutions and branches on Thursday. It stated that recognised colleges and universities seeking internship placements for students would have to apply at least 40 days before the start of an academic session or semester.

Students from disciplines such as social work, psychology, sociology, criminology, public administration, child development and allied subjects will be eligible for placement, it said.

The WCD department said interns may be attached to welfare schemes and outreach programmes under strict child protection safeguards. Photography and recording inside institutions have been restricted, while confidentiality norms and faculty monitoring during internships have also been made mandatory.

Delhi government directs departments to prevent electricity misuse and adopt energy-efficient ways

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has directed all the departments to prevent "misuse" of electricity and ensure its rational usage by cutting down unnecessary lighting, using natural light and maintaining air conditioning in energy-efficient manner, officials said on Thursday.

The government has already adopted various measures to cut down on use of fuel and other resources, including use of Metro trains and public transport by the chief minister, cabinet ministers, officers, work from home and less use of official vehicles in the wake of



the impact of global uncertainties on the country's economy.

A recent order issued by the General Administration Department (GAD) of the government directed the departments to take measures for "prevention of misuse and

“Unnecessary use of lighting fixtures during daytime will be avoided and natural lighting may be optimally utilised wherever feasible”

rationalisation of electricity consumption" in the offices.

In pursuance of the appeal made by Prime Minister Narendra Modi regarding saving fuels and energy, it has been decided to undertake measures for prevention of misuse and

rationalisation of electricity consumption, it said.

All heads of departments of various departments and autonomous bodies, and local bodies under the government jurisdiction will ensure judicious and need-based use of electricity at the offices and establishments under their administrative control, the order said.

"Unnecessary use of lighting fixtures during daytime will be avoided and natural lighting may be optimally utilised wherever feasible," said the order.

Over-lighting of rooms, corridors, common areas and office premises will be avoided, and only essential lighting as

per functional requirement will be ensured. Installation of master switches to ensure switching off lights and electrical equipment when not in use will be practised to prevent avoidable electricity consumption, it said.

Further, the order said that air-conditioners will be operated in an energy-efficient manner, maintaining the temperature around 24-26 degrees Celsius. Unnecessary cooling of office spaces should be avoided and coolers, air conditioners, computers, printers, photocopiers and other appliances should be switched off after office hours, it directed.

ZOO TOURS, HERITAGE WALKS, CONSERVATION SESSIONS

Students explore biodiversity as zoo's summer camp stresses conservation and climate action

NEW DELHI: The National Zoological Park here has concluded the first session of its Summer Vacation Programme, with students participating in activities related to biodiversity conservation, wildlife protection and sustainable living.

Organised under the Mission LiFE campaign and aligned with the World Environment Day theme "Inspired by Nature, For Climate, For Our Future", the week-long programme aimed to create awareness among school students on environmental conservation and climate action, a statement said.

According to the statement, the programme received 854 online registrations from schools across Delhi-NCR.



During the first session, 54 students from 18 schools participated in various activities.

The programme included expert lectures, guided zoo tours, heritage walks, conservation awareness sessions, photography workshops, educational visits and interactive discussions with scientists and conservation experts, it stated.

The sessions began with an

orientation programme and guided zoo tour focusing on herbivores and carnivores, it stated, adding that scientist Fayaz Khudsar from the Yamuna Biodiversity Park addressed students on conservation and environmental challenges, including urban heat islands and human impact on nature.

Zoo Director Sanjeet Kumar said involving chil-

dren in conservation activities is crucial for instilling environmental responsibility at a young age.

Other sessions focused on Mission LiFE, sustainable lifestyles and wildlife photography.

Scientist C R Magesh from the National Museum of Natural History spoke about sustainable living practices, while Sharad Gaur, scientist (retd) from the Centre for Environment Education, conducted a session on nature photography and conservation awareness, the statement said.

As part of World Turtle Day activities, students participated in art and craft exercises and discussions on turtle conservation and the impact of climate change on wildlife, it added. PII

DU allows alternative exam date for students missing tests on Eid

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The University of Delhi has allowed students unable to appear for examinations scheduled on Eid-ul-Adha to take the test on an alternative date after concerns were raised by students and student organisations over exams coinciding with the festival.

The decision came after protests by members of the All India Students' Association, who criticised the university administration for conducting first-year examinations on an important religious festival observed by Muslim students. Protesters alleged that students' concerns were not addressed adequately and called for greater sensitivity towards religious and cultural diversity on campus.



Following discussions and growing demands from students, the university clarified that examinations scheduled for May 28 would continue as per the existing timetable. However, students unable to appear for the examination due to the festival would be given another opportunity to write the exam after July 4.

Students seeking to avail

themselves of the option have been asked to contact their Principal or Head of Department and formally communicate their concerns to the university authorities.

The university further stated that students facing genuine medical or personal difficulties could also approach their departments for consideration. Officials indicated that departments and college administrations would take a "general and fair decision" based on individual circumstances.

The development has brought relief to several students who had demanded flexibility in the examination schedule while also reigniting discussions on inclusivity and accommodation of religious observances within academic institutions.

'EVEN ORDINARY WORKERS CAN RISE TO TOP POSTS IN BJP'

‘Change of leadership is like a relay race’, says new Delhi BJP prez Harsh Malhotra

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The new president of BJP's Delhi unit, Harsh Malhotra, on Thursday said change of guard is like a relay race and asserted to work towards strengthening the party's organisation with the cooperation of workers and the guidance of the senior leaders.

Accompanied by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, outgoing Delhi BJP president Virendra Sachdeva, party MPs Ramvir Bidhuri, Manoj Tiwari, Bansuri Swaraj, Kamaljeet Sehrawat, Delhi government ministers and other senior party leaders, Malhotra took charge as the state president at the party office here.

Addressing his maiden press conference as Delhi BJP chief, Malhotra said he intended to work alongside



Outgoing Delhi BJP President Virendra Sachdeva, along with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta, felicitates Harsh Deep Malhotra

lakhs of party workers, senior leaders and functionaries to ensure the party reached new heights.

"Change of leadership is like a relay race and I have been given this responsibility. I am fortunate to received the well wishes and blessing of my

predecessors, including (ex-Union minister) Harsh Vardhan," He said. Malhotra said he will also work to strengthen the efforts of the Rekha Gupta government in Delhi.

He thanked Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Union Home Minister Amit Shah

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Malhotra said he will also work to strengthen the efforts of the Rekha Gupta government in Delhi
- » He thanked Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Union Home Minister Amit Shah and BJP chief Nitin Nabin for being given charge of the BJP's Delhi unit

and BJP chief Nitin Nabin for being given charge of the BJP's Delhi unit. "This demonstrates the strength and beauty of the Bharatiya Janata Party. In the BJP, even an ordinary party worker can be entrusted with the highest responsibilities. I was made an MP and then a

minister, and now being given the responsibility of leading the Delhi BJP, such opportunities are possible only in the BJP," Malhotra said.

Chief Minister Gupta extended her well wishes to Malhotra saying his working style was well known to party leaders and workers. He will take care of everyone in the party like his family, she said.

She also praised Sachdeva for working hard to strengthen the party during his tenure, and underlined that it was under his leadership that the BJP returned to power in Delhi after 27 years.

Sachdeva, who completed his three-year tenure in March this year, said the BJP government was working with complete dedication to serve the Delhi people. He congratulated Malhotra and said under his leadership, the party will attain new heights in Delhi.

Delhi plans to operate two hydrogen buses in tie-up with NTPC: Minister

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government plans to operate two hydrogen-powered buses in the national capital as part of its push towards clean energy and sustainable public transport, Transport Minister Pankaj Singh said on Thursday.

The Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) is working on a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with state-owned NTPC Limited, which will provide the buses under its Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) initiative.

"Delhi is steadily moving towards clean, future-ready public mobility solutions. Hydrogen fuel technology represents an important step in our journey towards sustainable and environmentally responsible transport systems," Singh said.

As part of the proposed operational framework, an initial deployment of hydrogen fuel cell buses is being undertaken in coordination with NTPC.



CLOSER LOOK

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» An initial deployment of hydrogen fuel cell buses is being undertaken in coordination with NTPC

The buses are proposed to operate under the Gross

Cost Contract (GCC) model, with DTC facilitating operational deployment.

According to officials, costs beyond the approved GCC rate of Rs 45 per kilometre will be borne by the NTPC.

"Under the proposed arrangement, operational expenditure at approved GCC rates would be borne by DTC, while support for costs beyond the GCC framework is being explored through NTPC's CSR mechanism," the minister said.

Singh said that the initiative aims to introduce advanced hydrogen fuel cell technology into Delhi's public transport ecosystem, complementing the city's ongoing clean mobility transition and environmentally sustainable transport solutions.

"Through collaboration with organisations such as NTPC, we are exploring innovative pathways to introduce advanced zero-emission technologies that can strengthen Delhi's public transport network while contributing to cleaner air and a greener future," he added.

Centre, Delhi govt working on six road projects to decongest major NCR intersections: CM

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a push to decongest thoroughfares between Delhi and other NCR cities, the Delhi government and Centre will jointly undertake six major road projects, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta announced on Thursday.

The move comes a week after Union Minister of Road Transport and Highways Nitin Gadkari and the Delhi chief minister held a review in this regard, during which discussions were held on a decongestion plan for major NCR roads.

One of the approved plans include the 'Urban Extension Road-II (UER-II) Delhi-Dehradun Expressway Link Project'.

Under the project, a nearly 17-km-long six-lane corridor will connect the Delhi-Dehradun Expressway with UER-II near Tronica City in Ghaziabad, at an estimated cost of Rs 3,500 crore.

"The project is expected to reduce traffic pressure on routes such as IGI Airport, Barapullah corridor, Mukarba Chowk, Singhu Border and the Ashram-Badapur stretch. The project is currently in the alignment finalisation stage, with construction targeted to begin by December 2026," the CHO said in a statement.

The chief minister said the Centre and Delhi government will jointly undertake a series of large-scale road projects, with all of them designed in view of future traffic requirements.

Another proposed project is the 'Delhi-Dehradun Expressway Noida-Faridabad Connectivity Corridor'. Spanning around 65 km and featuring six lanes, its cost is estimated at Rs 7,500 crore.

"The corridor will connect the Delhi-Dehradun Expressway, Delhi-Meerut Expressway, DND, Faridabad and the Yamuna Expressway," the CMO said.

It is expected to improve connectivity for Loni, Baghpat, Ghaziabad, Noida and Faridabad while reducing congestion at Kalindi Kunj, Sarai Kale Khan and the Outer Ring Road. Work is expected to commence by December 2026.

The chief minister also highlighted a project linking the Delhi-Amritsar-Katra corridor with UER-II.

"Under the proposal, traffic from the Delhi-Katra Expressway will gain direct access to Delhi, Gurugram and IGI Airport through UER-II and the Dwarka Expressway. The 17-km, six-lane corridor, estimated to cost Rs 1,500 crore, is targeted to begin by March 2027," Gupta said.

To decongest Kalindi Kunj areas, authorities plan to construct an "interchange" near the Okhla barrage to improve traffic flow on the Delhi-Noida-Faridabad corridor.

The Delhi government announced multiple road infrastructure projects, including elevated corridors, flyovers and tunnels, aimed at easing congestion.

Delhi rejects irregularity claims in Ayushman Arogya Mandirs

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government on Thursday dismissed claims of wrongful expenditure on Ayushman Arogya Mandirs, saying all centres were developed strictly under the financial norms and technical guidelines prescribed by the Centre.

In a statement, the Health and Family Welfare Department said the development and operationalisation of the centres was carried out in accordance with the approved funding framework under centrally sponsored

healthcare schemes.

The clarification came after media reports alleged irregularities in the construction, upgradation and maintenance of Ayushman Arogya Mandirs, and claimed that the expenditure incurred on the centres exceeded the approved norms.

Rejecting the allegations, the department said suggestions that existing facilities were merely cosmetically modified or that spending exceeded sanctioned limits were "factually incorrect".

According to the government, each Ayushman Arogya Mandir has been allotted Rs 25

Each Ayushman Arogya Mandir has been allotted Rs 25 lakh for infrastructure upgradation and Rs 1 lakh for furniture, fixtures and essential requirements

lakh for infrastructure upgradation and Rs 1 lakh for furniture, fixtures and essential requirements under the Centre's approved framework.

A total of 370 Ayushman Arogya Mandirs were operationalised across Delhi during the 2025-26 financial year to strengthen primary healthcare access, it said.

Of these, 244 centres were developed under the Pradhan Mantri Ayushman Bharat Health Infrastructure Mission (PM-ABHIM) and 126 under the National Health Mission (NHM).

The government said Rs 58.30 crore has been released under PM-ABHIM and Rs 8.50 crore under NHM so

far, taking the total funds released to Rs 66.80 crore.

"Any claims suggesting substantially higher expenditure figures on the presently operationalised centres are misleading and inconsistent with officially sanctioned and released financial data," the statement said.

The department said the Ayushman Arogya Mandirs were aimed not only at physical renovation but also at strengthening neighbourhood healthcare delivery through improved infrastructure, diagnostics, preventive care services and wellness initiatives.

Delhi Health Minister Dr Pankaj Kumar Singh said healthcare infrastructure expansion in the national capital was being implemented with "complete transparency and strict adherence to Government of India guidelines".

"Every Ayushman Arogya Mandir has been developed under approved financial norms and established procedures. Misinterpretation of financial figures without reference to sanctioned allocations and actual fund releases risks creating unnecessary confusion regarding an important public healthcare initiative," he said.

Delhi mandates IoT-based real-time monitoring system for fire safety infrastructure in buildings

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has mandated the installation of an Internet of Things (IoT)-based automated continuous monitoring system (ACMS) in specified buildings to digitally monitor fire prevention and life safety systems in real time by sending alerts through SMS, according to a recent gazette notification.

The new provision, introduced under the Delhi Fire Service (Amendment) Rules, aims to ensure that both active and passive fire safety measures in buildings remain functional, well-maintained and capable of responding during emergencies.

Under the rules, the ACMS will monitor the operational status of critical firefighting infrastructure, including hydrant pumps, sprinkler systems, fire water tanks, detection systems, manual call points, public address systems, pres-

The monitoring system will function through IoT gateways connected to cloud-based servers that will generate real-time alerts and reports for owners, occupiers...

surisation fans and basement ventilation systems.

The monitoring system will function through IoT gateways connected to cloud-based servers that will generate real-time alerts and reports for owners, occupiers and empanelled fire safety auditors through mobile applications, emails and SMS alerts.

The implementation of the system will take place in two phases. In the first phase, which comes into effect immediately after the notification of the rules, alerts and system health reports will be accessible to building owners, occupiers and fire safety auditors.

In the second phase, critical alarms such as pump power

failures, low hydrant and sprinkler pressure, and fire alarm faults will also be directly transmitted to the Delhi Fire Service (DFS).

The rules specify that the monitoring system must digitally track key firefighting components such as main hydrant pumps, diesel and electric standby pumps, jockey pumps, booster pumps, underground and overhead fire water tanks, sprinkler risers and fire alarm control panels.

The system will also monitor operational status of manual call points, public address systems, staircase pressurisation fans, lift lobby pressurisation systems and basement exhaust fans.

According to the notification, the IoT system must use machine-to-machine communication based on MQTTs protocol and support cloud connectivity through 4G, 5G, Ethernet, Wi-Fi or any other reliable wired or wireless medium. Data from the systems will be uploaded every minute for real-time monitoring.

The cloud portal will generate alarms if no data is received from the gateway for more than 15 minutes to ensure reliability of the monitoring mechanism. The gateway is also required to have a seven-hour power backup and storage capacity for at least 10,000 event logs with timestamp records.

A DFS officer said that the digital system is intended to strengthen maintenance, accountability and emergency response capabilities in high-risk buildings by ensuring continuous surveillance of fire safety infrastructure.

Rain brings relief from scorching heat

IMD issues red alert for thunderstorm and hailstorm

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: After days of sweltering heatwave conditions, Delhiites got a respite on Thursday as heavy rain, thunderstorms and gusty winds swept parts of the national capital, with the India Meteorological Department (IMD) issuing a red alert for the next few hours.

The IMD warned of moderate to severe thunderstorms accompanied by lightning, duststorms and isolated hailstorms at many places across the city, with wind speeds likely to reach 80 kilometres per hour. The weather office said the current spell of rain and thunderstorm activity is expected to continue till May 31.

The change in weather comes after several days of intense heat during which temperatures crossed the 45 degrees Celsius mark at various stations in Delhi. According to IMD data, maximum temperatures across the city on Thursday fell by around 3 to 5 degrees Celsius compared to the previous day.

Delhi also recorded below-normal maximum tempera-



Thunderstorm activity has already begun over northern parts of Rajasthan and is expected to spread to Delhi...

tures across major weather stations on Thursday, the IMD said. "Thunderstorm activity has already begun over northern parts of Rajasthan and is expected to spread to Delhi by evening and continue through the night," said Mahesh Palawat, Skymet Weather.

He said the intensity of the storms is likely to increase on Friday and the spell is expected to continue till May 30, after which the weather system is likely to shift towards Gujarat between May 30 and 31.

"The current spell of pre-monsoon rains is likely to be stronger than the pre-monsoon showers witnessed in Delhi earlier this month and in April, leading to widespread rainfall activity across the city," Palawat said. He attributed the weather activity to a western disturbance over the hills, an induced cyclonic circulation over Rajasthan and adjoining areas, along with humid winds from the Bay of Bengal that have increased moisture levels over the city.

AAP claims water crisis worsening due to vacant CEO post at DJB

NEW DELHI: The Aam Aadmi Party on Thursday alleged that the water crisis in Delhi had worsened as the post of chief executive officer of the Delhi Jal Board (DJB) had remained vacant for more than a month.

Addressing a press conference, AAP Delhi chief Saurabh Bharadwaj accused the BJP-led Delhi government of failing to prepare for the spike in water demand during summer. He claimed several areas were facing disrupted supply for days, while some localities had not received regular water supply for weeks.

Bharadwaj alleged that the absence of a DJB CEO had delayed key policy decisions and affected water management during the ongoing heatwave. He also claimed residents in many parts of the city were waiting late into the night for water tankers. Calling the situation unprecedented, Bharadwaj said such a prolonged vacancy had never occurred earlier. There was no immediate response from the BJP.

Delhi govt to set up solar-powered ‘cooling hut’ as pilot heat relief proj

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

NEW DELHI: In a new initiative to provide relief from the scorching summer heat, the Delhi government is launching a solar-powered public cooling structure in northwest Delhi as a pilot project, an official said on Thursday.

Additional structures are planned, which will offer shaded resting spaces equipped with mist-based cooling facilities. Designed in the shape of a small hut, the structure will use traditional khush grass padding on all sides along with a sprinkler system to create a natural cooling effect for visitors sitting inside, the official said.

The facility, currently under construction, is expected to be completed by the end of May and inaugurated by Chief Minister Rekha Gupta in the first week of June in Shalimar Bagh, according to the official.

People visiting the cooling hut will have access to seating arrangements, cold drinking water dispensers and charg-



ing sockets for mobile phones. Solar panels installed on the roof will power the facility, making it energy-efficient and suitable for use during peak summer months.

"The idea is to create a public cooling zone where people, especially labourers, commuters and residents exposed to extreme heat, can sit for a while and get relief from high temperatures," he said.

The misting effect generated through the khush grass and sprinklers is expected to help lower the surrounding temperature and reduce the risk of heat-related illnesses such as heatstroke.

He also said that the Shali-

A public cooling space aimed at offering temp relief from extreme heat to labourers, commuters, local residents

mar Bagh installation will function as a pilot project. If the public response is encouraging and the model proves effective, similar cooling huts may be installed in other parts of the city in the coming months.

The initiative comes amid continuing heatwave conditions in the national capital, where the Delhi government has been expanding relief measures through mobile cooling units and temporary cooling zones.

As part of its ongoing heat action campaign, the government has provided relief to around 2.65 lakh people between May 6 and May 23 through mobile heat relief units

deployed across Delhi, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta had said earlier this week.

During the same period, around 1,13,900 litres of cold drinking water were distributed, along with 44,646 gamchas and 30,864 caps to help people protect themselves from heatstroke, according to official figures.

Officials said cooling zones and relief facilities are being established in different districts of the city where people can take short breaks from the heat and access drinking water and shade.

"Similar facilities are also being started in the remaining districts this week, and the campaign will continue till July," Gupta had said.

Delhi has experienced prolonged high temperatures over the past few weeks, with the city recording its hottest night in 14 years on Monday, registering a minimum temperature of 32.4 degrees Celsius, which is 5.6 degrees above the seasonal average.

'RESPONSIBLE NATIONS HAVE TO EVALUATE THEIR CHOICES'

OPERATION SHERUWALI ENTERS DAY 6

No ‘double standards’ in fight against terrorism, says NSA Doval in Russia

MOSCOW: National Security Adviser Ajit Doval called for decisive action against terrorism and said there cannot be “double standards” in the fight against it, while addressing an international security forum in Russia on Thursday, according to the Indian Embassy in Moscow.

Doval participated in the first International Security Forum and the 14th Meeting of High Representatives for Security Matters in Moscow.

“The meeting was hosted by Mr. Sergei Shoigu, Secretary of the Security Council of the Russian Federation,” the embassy said in a post on X, adding that the forum deliberated on the “Challenges and Threats to International Security in the context of the Emergence of the Multipolar World”.

“(The) NSA stated that there cannot be double standards in the fight against terrorism. Responsible nations have to evaluate their choices and decide whether they support sponsors of terrorism or counter them with decisive action,” the embassy said.



NSA Ajit Doval with Russia Security Council Secretary Sergei Shoigu on the sidelines of the first International Security Forum, in Moscow, Russia

Doval also “highlighted the urgent need for reforms in the structures and institutions set up after the end of the Second World War in 1945 to make them effective in dealing with contemporary international security threats”.

“The reforms must give greater representation to and factor in the views of the Global South,” it said.

Referring to the situation in West Asia, Doval was quoted as

saying it was essential to ensure “the safe and uninterrupted movement of trade through international waterways including the Strait of Hormuz and the Red Sea”.

On the sidelines of the forum, Doval held a meeting with his Russian counterpart Shoigu, the Indian Embassy said in another post.

“During the meeting, the parties reviewed the current state of cooperation in the areas

Highlights

» Doval also ‘highlighted the urgent need for reforms in the structures and institutions set up after the end of Second World War in 1945’

» ‘The reforms must give greater representation to and factor in the views of Global South’

» Doval also held a meeting with his Russian counterpart Shoigu, the Indian Embassy said

of defence, security, energy, and trade-economic ties,” it said.

The two officials also exchanged views on preparations for the upcoming meeting of BRICS national security advisers to be held in New Delhi, the mission said.

The specific dates for the BRICS national security advisers’ meeting have not yet been officially announced.

Doval’s visit to Russia comes amid a fragile geopolitical situa-

tion marked by continuing conflict in West Asia, concerns over maritime security in key global trade routes, and sharpening competition among major powers over the emerging multipolar world order.

The Strait of Hormuz, which has been effectively blocked for three months now, because of the conflict, and the Red Sea are among the world’s most critical shipping corridors.

They carry a substantial share of global energy supplies and commercial trade. Any disruption in these waterways has implications for energy prices, supply chains and economic stability across Asia and beyond.

The visit also comes as the Russia-Ukraine conflict continues to weigh on global security and economic stability, with Moscow’s ties with the West remaining strained more than four years after the war began.

The conflict has reshaped geopolitical alignments, disrupted energy and food supply chains, and intensified debates over the future global security architecture.

AGENCIES

J&K: Security forces launch fresh assault on terrorist hideouts

OUR CORRESPONDENT

JAMMU: Security forces on Thursday launched a fresh fire assault and multiple grenade launcher (MGL) attacks on specific suspected terrorist hideouts as the anti-terror operation Sheruwali in the dense forests of Jammu and Kashmir’s Rajouri district entered its sixth consecutive day.

According to preliminary reports, two to three Pakistani terrorists, including a commander, are believed to be hiding in the area. The fresh assault came a day after Northern Army Commander Lieutenant General Pratik Sharma visited the area and reviewed the ongoing anti-terror operation in the dense forests.

Officials said that the fresh fire assault was launched on suspected hideouts in the Dorimal-Gambhir Moghla belt of the Manjakote area amid narrowing down of the cordon to eliminate terrorists believed to be hiding in the region. The firing and MGL assaults resulted in plumes of smoke rising from the forested areas, indicating that the targeted locations were struck during the operation, they said.

Security forces, which were



following blood stains believed to have been left behind by the fleeing terrorists on Monday, have been closely tracking the suspected movement of the ultras, officials said. On Monday, security forces busted a hideout after a brief exchange of fire amid strengthening of the cordon around the area where blood stains were detected.

Backed by helicopters, drones and sniffer dogs, joint teams of the Army, Jammu and Kashmir Police and paramilitary forces are conducting extensive searches in the adjoining areas. The cordon around the operation zone has been further strengthened with the induction of additional troops, officials said.

Amid intensified checking

of vehicles on roads connected to the area, more reinforcements have been rushed to the forests of Dori Maal in the Gambhir Moghla area, where the anti-terror operation is underway, they added.

On Saturday, an encounter broke out between terrorists and security forces in the Dorimal-Gambhir Moghla belt after a joint team launched the operation following intelligence inputs about the presence of terrorists in the Singhpura-Chattroo area.

A joint team of the Army, Jammu and Kashmir Police and the CRPF had launched a massive cordon-and-search operation in the area based on specific information about the movement of suspected terrorists.

Parliamentary panel summons Education Ministry, NTA, CBI officials over conduct of exams

NEW DELHI: A parliamentary panel has summoned officials of the Union Education Ministry, the National Testing Agency (NTA) and the CBI to appear before it on Friday in connection with the assurances pertaining to the conduct of examinations by the testing agency.

According to a notice issued by the Rajya Sabha Secretariat on May 27, the Committee on

Government Assurances will hear the views of Vineet Joshi, Secretary of the Department of Higher Education, Ministry of Education, along with Abhishek Singh, Director General of NTA and Praveen Sood, Director of CBI.

The committee meeting is scheduled for 11 am on Friday.

The matter pertains to an assurance given in Rajya Sabha in reply to an unstarred ques-

tion (USQ) dated November 27, 2024, regarding “Conduct of Examination by NTA”, the notice said.

In its written reply to the question in November, 2024, the Education Ministry had stated that as informed by NTA, contracts for conducting examinations are awarded to agencies “as per the extant rules, orders and guidelines issued by the Government of India”.



The ministry had also informed the House that complaints against vendors are dealt

with in accordance with the terms and conditions laid down in the work order or tender document and action ranges “from deduction of payment to debarment” upon ascertaining deficiency of service.

On the NEET-UG 2024 paper leak case, the ministry had said the CBI was conducting a “comprehensive investigation into the entire gamut of alleged irregularities including

conspiracy, cheating, breach of trust etc.” and had filed five charge sheets against 45 accused as on November 22, 2024.

The NEET-UG for admissions into medical courses took place on May 3 this year but was cancelled by the NTA on May 12 amid allegations of a paper leak. The CBI is currently investigating this matter, and a retest is scheduled for June 21.

The committee will also

hear the views of Secretary of Union Health and Family Welfare Punya Salila Srivastava, National Medical Commission (NMC) chairman Abhijit Chandrakant Sheth and CBI Director regarding an assurance given in reply to Rajya Sabha USQ dated 29 July, 2025 regarding “Medical College Scam”, according to the notice.

On the “Medical College Scam”, the Health Ministry in

a written reply had informed Rajya Sabha in July 2025 that the CBI had lodged an FIR in New Delhi under provisions of the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita and the Prevention of Corruption Act in connection with alleged irregularities involving dummy faculty, fake inspections and falsified patient records. The ministry had said the matter was under investigation by the CBI.

AGENCIES

From Page 1

Siddaramaiah

Maharashtra,” Siddaramaiah claimed, while alleging that the previous BJP government had financially damaged the state.

Following his resignation, protests erupted in several parts of Karnataka by Siddaramaiah supporters, while celebrations broke out near Shivakumar’s residence amid indications that he would become the next chief minister.

Soon after the press conference, Siddaramaiah left for New Delhi, where discussions with the Congress high command on cabinet formation and leadership changes are expected. Shivakumar, who is also the Karnataka Congress president, also left for Delhi.

According to party sources, discussions on the new legislature party leader, cabinet composition and the state Congress chief’s post are likely to take place over the next two days.

The Congress had witnessed a fierce contest between Siddaramaiah and Shivakumar for the chief minister’s post after the party’s victory in the May 2023 Assembly elections, eventually persuading Shivakumar to accept the deputy chief minister’s role.

Earlier in the day, Siddaramaiah informed ministers during a break-fast meeting at his residence that he would step down and that Shivakumar would succeed him as per the Congress leadership’s directions, ministers present at the meeting said.

US, Iran

the attack around Bandar Abbas International Airport.

The Iranian force said via the state-run IRNA news agency that it launched a retaliatory attack on the air base that launched the assaults, without specifying whether the retaliation targeted Kuwait, which is home to US Army Central’s forward headquarters, air bases and a naval base.

Kuwait’s military announced that its air-defence systems intercepted incoming missiles and drones on Thursday, without detailing what had been targeted. Kuwait repeatedly came under fire from Iran and Iranian-backed Shiite militias in Iraq before the April ceasefire began.

The announcement comes as the Middle East is on the edge and talks to end the war remain in flux.

Trump is looking for an agreement that will reopen the Strait,

through which about a fifth of all traded oil and natural gas once passed. He also is seeking to get Iran to give up its stockpile of highly enriched uranium. The war has been unpopular in the US, and Iran’s closure of the strait has sent oil prices skyrocketing, driving up fuel prices around the world.

The Islamic Republic wants economic sanctions to be lifted and frozen assets to be released to aid its shattered economy. Iran also insists that any deal must include an end to Israel’s military operations in Lebanon against the Iranian-backed militant group Hezbollah.

A US-brokered ceasefire went into effect in Lebanon in mid-April, and Lebanese and Israeli military officials are set to hold their first security talks Friday in Washington. But the ceasefire has been tested, and Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu warned Monday that his country was stepping up attacks after Hezbollah fired fiber-optic exploding drones that struck Israeli troops in Lebanon and reached some of Israel’s northern border towns.

Tensions deepened Thursday as Israel conducted an airstrike on a southern suburb of the capital, Beirut, and other strikes in the southern coastal city of Tyre. At least 14 people were killed across the country’s south.

India, China

India also raised the issue of holding an early meeting of the expert-level mechanism on trans-border rivers.

Both countries agreed to continue diplomatic and military-level communication through existing channels, including mechanisms created after the 24th round of Special Representatives talks.

The two sides also decided to make “substantive preparation” for the next meeting of the Special Representatives, which is scheduled to take place in China.

In August last year, National Security Adviser Ajit Doval and Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi held Special Representatives dialogue in New Delhi. The talks resulted in several measures aimed at maintaining peace along the border.

The Indian delegation at the WMCC meeting was led by Sujit Ghosh, Joint Secretary (East Asia) in the MEA. The Chinese side was headed by Hou Yanqi, Director General of the Boundary and Oceanic Affairs Department in the Chinese foreign ministry.

During his visit, Ghosh also met Liu Jinsong from the Chinese foreign ministry’s Department of Asian Affairs and paid a courtesy call on Chinese Assistant Foreign Minister

Hong Lei.

The meeting in Beijing took place amid continued diplomatic engagement between the two neighbours. In August last year, Modi visited the Chinese city of Tianjin to attend the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation summit, where he held extensive talks with Xi on the sidelines of the event.

During those discussions, Modi said India remained committed to advancing ties with China based on “mutual trust, mutual respect and mutual sensitivity”.

Rain brings

evening, offering relief after days of sweltering heat. The India Meteorological Department (IMD) issued a red alert for the next few hours and warned of moderate to severe thunderstorms accompanied by lightning, dust storms and isolated hailstorms across many parts of the city.

According to the IMD, wind speeds during the storm activity could reach up to 80 kilometres per hour. The weather office said the current spell of rain and thunderstorms is likely to continue till May 31.

The change came after several days during which temperatures crossed the 45 degrees Celsius mark at different weather stations in Delhi. IMD data showed that maximum temperatures in the city dropped by around 3 to 5 degrees Celsius on Thursday compared to the previous day.

Mahesh Palawat of Skymet Weather said the intensity of storms is likely to increase on Friday and the weather activity may continue till May 30. He added that the weather system is expected to shift towards Gujarat between May 30 and 31.

While Delhi received some relief, large parts of Uttar Pradesh continued to face intense heat on Thursday. Banda was the hottest place in the state with a maximum temperature of 47.5 degrees Celsius, according to the IMD.

The Meteorological Centre in Lucknow said Jhansi recorded 46.5 degrees Celsius, Orai 44.8 degrees Celsius and Agra 43.3 degrees Celsius. Kanpur city registered 42.2 degrees Celsius, while Aligarh touched 42.8 degrees Celsius. Hamirpur also recorded 42.2 degrees Celsius and Lakhimpur Kheri touched 42 degrees Celsius. Prayagraj recorded 41 degrees Celsius and Churk in Sonbhadra logged 40.3 degrees Celsius.

Lucknow, however, remained relatively cooler with a maximum temperature of 37.4 degrees Celsius, which was 2.7 notches below normal. The minimum tempera-

ture in the city settled at 27.3 degrees Celsius.

The IMD has forecast rain and thunderstorms in many parts of Uttar Pradesh over the next 24 hours. Thunderstorms accompanied by lightning and dust storms are likely at isolated places in western Uttar Pradesh with wind speeds between 80 and 100 kilometres per hour. Eastern Uttar Pradesh may witness similar conditions with winds reaching 70 to 90 kilometres per hour.

Rajasthan also remained under the grip of intense heat. Sri Ganganagar recorded the highest temperature in the state at 47.1 degrees Celsius. Churu registered 46.5 degrees Celsius, while Kota and Pilani recorded 46.4 degrees Celsius each. Jaipur recorded 45.4 degrees Celsius and Bikaner 45.3 degrees Celsius.

The weather department has issued an alert for thunderstorms, lightning and rain activity in parts of Rajasthan due to the influence of a fresh western disturbance. Northern districts are likely to witness strong winds and light rainfall over the coming days.

In Uttarakhand, the IMD warned of heavy rainfall, thunderstorms and hail in several districts on Friday. Light to moderate rain and snowfall above 3,800 metres are expected across many parts of the state. Alerts have been issued for Uttarkashi, Dehradun, Tehri, Rudrapur, Chamoli, Bageshwar and Pithoragarh districts.

The Shimla Met office also issued an orange warning for parts of Himachal Pradesh, forecasting hail, thunderstorms, lightning and gusty winds in five districts on Friday. The state is expected to witness wet weather till June 3.

Meanwhile, Haryana and Punjab continued to experience hot weather conditions. Sirsa in Haryana and Faridkot in Punjab were the hottest places in the two states, both recording 45.4 degrees Celsius.

CBI nabs

vacation judge Justice Devnaranayan Mishra observed in a 17-page order on Wednesday that “in light of the factual aspects of the case and the allegations levelled against the respondent”, the anticipatory bail order passed by the additional sessions judge deserved to be quashed.

Appearing for the CBI, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta submitted that the manner in which anticipatory bail was obtained raised doubts over whether the trial court had adequately considered the relevant aspects required for granting such relief, the order noted.

The CBI recently took over the probe from the Madhya Pradesh Police after Twisha Sharma’s family met Chief Minister Mohan Yadav and demanded a CBI inquiry.

The agency formally assumed charge of the investigation on Monday into the death of Twisha Sharma, who was allegedly found hanging at her matrimonial home in Bhopal on May 12. The CBI subsequently re-registered the FIR lodged by the state police, naming Samarth Singh and Giribala Singh as accused.

Officials said the CBI plans to confront Giribala Singh and Samarth Singh with each other’s statements and question them in custody regarding the circumstances leading to Twisha’s death. The agency is expected to produce Giribala Singh before a competent court to seek her remand.

During the hearing, counsel appearing for Twisha’s family argued that she was allegedly subjected to continuous mental harassment and was “badly stuck” in her matrimonial home.

“Finally, justice has been done in the Twisha case,” the counsel told reporters.

The petitioners also alleged before the court that Giribala Singh attempted to influence evidence after securing anticipatory bail.

According to submissions made before the court, police had seized CCTV footage from Giribala Singh’s residence on May 13, but selective clips were later circulated on social media allegedly with the intention of influencing the investigation.

The prosecution argued that given the seriousness of the allegations and the circumstances surrounding the case, the trial court ought to have examined the evidence more carefully before granting anticipatory bail, sources said.

NEET papers

Sources said PMO officials will closely supervise the entire chain of operations to prevent any repeat of the controversy that triggered protests and political criticism over the credibility of India’s biggest medical entrance examination.

NEET-UG was conducted on May 3 in 551 cities across India and 14 overseas centres. According to the NTA, inputs regarding alleged malpractices were received on May 7 and shared with central agencies the following morning. The exam was cancelled on May 12.

The CBI later registered a case following a complaint from the Department of Higher Education and formed special investigation teams. So far, 13 people have

been arrested from Delhi, Jaipur, Gurugram, Nasik, Pune, Latur and Ahilyanagar.

Think it’s hot

years would surpass 2024 as the hottest year ever recorded.

According to the report, each year through 2030 is expected to be between 1.3 degrees Celsius and 1.9 degrees Celsius warmer than temperatures recorded in the late 1800s.

Melissa Seabrook, a climate scientist at the UK Meteorological Office and co-author of the report, said crossing the 1.5 degree threshold does not mean the world suddenly falls into catastrophe, but even small increases in temperature bring greater risks.

“It’s important to note that 1.5 is not kind of a cliff edge that we’re going to fall off,” Seabrook said. “Every kind of 0.1 of a degree has more and more severe impact.”

She pointed to unusually high temperatures recorded across Europe in May as one example of how warming is already affecting weather patterns.

Climate experts not involved in the report also warned that higher temperatures could place pressure on cities, food supplies and emergency systems.

Friederike Otto, a climate scientist at Imperial College London, said a full year above the 1.5 degree mark could bring weather conditions beyond what many countries have prepared for.

“This will mean many people will lose their lives, we are in for a lot of food price shocks, and more intense wildfires,” Otto said in an email response.

Scientists involved in the report said many shorter-term climate forecasts are pointing to the arrival of a strong El Nino event, a natural warming of parts of the Pacific Ocean that influences weather worldwide and often pushes global temperatures higher.

The WMO said the El Nino conditions could continue until 2028. Seabrook said that because of this, 2027 may become hotter than 2024, which currently holds the global temperature record.

The report also suggested that if the next five years average more than 1.5 degrees Celsius above pre-industrial levels, the pace of global warming would have accelerated sharply. That would mean the planet warmed about 0.25 degrees Celsius in a decade, compared with earlier warming rates of roughly 0.2 degrees Celsius every ten years.

Scientists are still debating whether climate change is speeding up faster than earlier projections suggested.

“Which obviously is quite scary,” Seabrook said, adding that the latest findings could support concerns that warming is accelerating.

The projections are based on nearly 200 computer simulations using 13 climate models developed by research institutions in several countries.

The report showed the Arctic continuing to warm much faster than the rest of the world. Seabrook said Arctic warming is happening about 3.5 times faster because shrinking ice and snow reduce the amount of sunlight reflected back into space.

“As the temperature warms, more sea ice melts, the worse this makes it,” she said.

According to the report, winters in the Arctic between 2020 and 2025 were already 1.2 degrees Celsius warmer than the 1991 to 2020 average. Over the next five winters, temperatures are projected to rise another 2.8 degrees Celsius above that recent average.

The report also forecast further losses of Arctic sea ice during summer months.

In South America, the Amazon basin is expected to experience hotter and drier conditions. Scientists warned this could increase wildfire risks and affect water supplies for millions of people. The Amazon rainforest currently absorbs large amounts of carbon dioxide, helping slow global warming. Scientists fear worsening drought and fires could weaken that role and eventually turn the region into a source of additional emissions.

The report also projected above-normal rainfall across Africa’s Sahel region, where dry conditions have affected communities in recent years. Scientists warned heavier rainfall could increase flood risks in the area.

United Nations officials said the findings showed that global action to slow climate change remains insufficient.

UN climate chief Simon Stiell said rising temperatures in Europe, India and other regions were already causing serious human and economic damage.

“Despite the progress of recent years, it’s clear that global heating is still outpacing global efforts to contain it,” Stiell said.

“Whether it’s extreme heat, mega-storms, floods, massive wildfires or droughts hitting food supply and prices,” he added, “every nation is already paying a huge price from this global climate crisis.”

'RAHUL FRUSTRATED, OPPOSED TO INDIA'S SCIENTIFIC PROGRESS'

Pradhan counters Rahul's charges as CBSE exam row deepens further

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan and Rahul Gandhi on Thursday engaged in a fierce public spat over the CBSE exam row, with Pradhan accusing Gandhi of politicising the issue and being frustrated and the Congress leader hitting back, asserting that attacking him would not absolve the union minister of his "crimes".

Pradhan's attack came after Gandhi alleged irregularities in the CBSE exam system and demanded an independent judicial probe and constitution of a Special Investigation Team (SIT) to unearth the truth behind the "entire scam". He also alleged that a firm with a murky past in Telangana was handed the contract by CBSE for digital evaluation of answer books.

Targeting Gandhi, Pradhan said the Leader of Opposition



Dharmendra Pradhan during a press conference

PTI

in Lok Sabha appeared "frustrated" due to continuous electoral defeats and accused him of opposing reforms and technological progress and accused him of politicising the issue.

"But as far as Rahul Gandhi is concerned, he seems to have reached a different state of mind. Due to continuous

electoral defeats, he appears frustrated. He opposed SIR, he used to oppose EVMs, and he opposed Digital India. He does not seem to stand with India's scientific progress," he said.

The minister emphasised that the CBSE's actions align with the Government of India's procurement policy and

CBSE backs OSM system

NEW DELHI: Amid the controversy over its On-Screen Marking System, the CBSE on Thursday asserted that it was a "secure and robust IT platform" and that no compromise or vulnerability has been reported in the actual evaluation portal.

The CBSE also said that the platform has been "tested and certified through empan-

elled security audits" and is supported by a "robust digital infrastructure" with multiple quality checks and safeguards for secure scanning and processing of answer books. Addressing students, the Board said on X that answer books are "safe" and have been processed through "multiple quality-control mechanisms".

AGENCIES

assured that if any irregularities are discovered, action will be taken against those responsible.

"As far as this issue is concerned, I take responsibility on behalf of the government for any inconvenience, and I request everyone that this is not the time for politics. I have said this earlier as well. Politics can be done later," he said.

Hitting back, Gandhi said:

"Dharmendra Pradhan ji, you can attack me all you want, but it won't absolve you of your crimes. Nor will it stop me from demanding answers for 18.5 lakh children."

Meanwhile, Pradhan also chaired a review meeting at the CBSE headquarters here to assess the progress of the Class 12 evaluation and post-result processes.

Nitin Nabin appoints new chiefs for BJP Delhi, Punjab, 2 other states

NEW DELHI: BJP national president Nitin Nabin on Thursday appointed new party chiefs for its four state units, naming Union minister Harsh Malhotra as the Delhi BJP president.

While Archana Gupta was appointed as the BJP Haryana president, Sardar Kewal Singh Dhillon was made the party's Punjab unit chief, according to separate notifications issued by party national general secretary Arun Singh.

Abhishek Debroy, an MLA from Matabari assembly constituency in Tripura, was made president of the BJP state unit.

"All these appointments come into force with immediate effect," Singh said.

Harsh Malhotra, 62, is the

Archana Gupta was appointed as the BJP Haryana president, Sardar Kewal Singh Dhillon is Punjab unit chief

only Union minister in the Modi Cabinet from Delhi. He replaces Virendra Sachdeva, who completed his three-year term as the Delhi BJP president in March this year.

Malhotra, who served as the general secretary of the Delhi unit of the BJP before becoming a minister at the Centre, is considered an expert on organisational matters as well as the

functioning of the civic bodies. In 2015, he was elected as mayor of the erstwhile East Delhi Municipal Corporation.

Archana Gupta, newly appointed Haryana BJP president, is a doctor by profession. She was serving the party as its state general secretary. Gupta takes over from Mohan Lal Badoli.

Gupta, who hails from Panipat, is the second woman after Kamla Verma, a veteran BJP leader, to lead the Haryana BJP as its president.

Sardar Kewal Singh Dhillon, a two-time former Congress MLA from Barnala, had joined the BJP in 2022 and was subsequently appointed vice-president of the state unit of the party.

MPOST

Day after ED action, Kerala remains on edge

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The ED searches at residences linked to former Kerala Chief Minister Pinarayi Vijayan triggered a fresh political storm on Thursday.

The Congress alleged that the searches were intended to shield the CPI(M) leader from mounting internal criticism, while the Left defended the protests against the central agency and the BJP strongly condemned the violence.

A day after the Enforcement Directorate conducted the searches and violence allegedly broke out against its officials, senior Congress leader and Kerala minister K Muralleedharan claimed the party suspected the ED action was aimed at protecting Vijayan, who was facing severe criticism from within the CPI(M).

The CPI(M), however,



CPI(M) members stage a protest against the ED raids

PTI

claimed there was no attack on ED officials and argued that the officials should have waited for protesters to calm down before leaving Vijayan's rented residence after the searches.

Earlier in the day, Muralleedharan reiterated that the Congress neither supported the ED nor the searches conducted by the agency, and claimed that

such action should have been initiated when Vijayan was serving as chief minister.

He, however, condemned the alleged attack by CPI(M) workers on vehicles carrying ED officials who had searched the former chief minister's rented residence in the state capital.

"Taking the law into one's

hands and disrupting law and order will not be condoned by the government," said the minister, who holds the Health and Devaswom portfolios.

He further said the Congress did not need to enter into any deal to politically destroy a leader who had already been "badly defeated" by the people.

"We suspect that the ED searches were a rescue attempt as they came at a time when Vijayan was facing severe criticism from within the party," he alleged.

CPI(M) leader M Swaraj, speaking at an event, claimed that no one had attacked the ED and that the incident outside Vijayan's residence could not be described as an attack.

He said the Left party leadership had made it clear that the protests should remain peaceful.

MPOST

WFI takes battle with Vinesh to SC

NEW DELHI: The Wrestling Federation of India has moved the Supreme Court challenging the Delhi High Court's order allowing grappler Vinesh Phogat to participate in the selection trials for the Asian Games 2026. A bench of Justices P S Narasimha and Alok Aradhe is scheduled to hear the Federation's plea on Friday.

On May 22, a division bench of the high court had given its nod to the participation of Phogat in the upcoming trials for the Asian Games, saying the WFI's selection policy was exclusionary for the lack of discretion to consider an iconic player like her, who is returning from a maternity break.

The high court had ordered that the selection trials, to be held on May 30-31, shall be video-recorded by the WFI and an independent observer from the Sports Authority of India (SAI) and the Indian Olympic Association (IOA) each shall also remain present.

"The appellant (Phogat) shall be permitted to participate in the selection trials for Asian Games, 2026, which are scheduled for May 30, 2026 and May 31, 2026," it had said.

The high court had said the standard for the selection trials marks significant deviation from the past practice, which provided for discretion for the selection of iconic players for the Asian Games, and added that the law must ensure that motherhood does not become a ground to exclude female athletes like Phogat. Motherhood, it had asserted, cannot be treated as a professional impediment.

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HP: Panchayat phase-II sees nearly 80% polling

SHIMLA: Nearly 80 per cent polling was recorded during the second phase of the Himachal Pradesh rural body elections for 1,276 panchayats on Thursday, with women voters surpassing men in turnout in nine out of 12 districts.

The percentages of female and male voters stood at 82.97 per cent and 76.69 per cent, respectively.

The poll percentage, which was 76 per cent in the second phase of Panchayat polls in 2021, increased to 79.79 per cent in the second phase in 2026, officials said.

The polling was peaceful and no untoward incidents have been reported from any part of the state, State Chief Election Commissioner Anil Khachi told PTI.

The highest turnout was recorded in Kullu district at 85.52 per cent, followed by 85.16 per cent in Sirmour, 83.62 per cent in Solan, 80.96 per cent in Mandi, and 80.68 per cent in Shimla.

Chamba recorded 79.99 per cent turnout, while Una saw 79.73 per cent, Bilaspur 78.95 per cent, Kangra 76.29 per cent, Kinnaur 76.29 per cent, and Hamirpur 74.94 per cent.

Lahaul and Spiti district recorded the lowest turnout at 69.38 per cent, according to official data. Villagers in Ward No 1 of Kangri under Greet Ram Panchayat in Hamirpur district boycotted the panchayat elections, citing years of stalled development work and the failure to resolve several pending issues.

Around 288 voters from Ward No 1 had issued an ultimatum to the authorities prior to the announcement of polling dates, saying they would boycott the rural body elections if their demands remained unmet. On Thursday, not a single person from the ward turned up to vote.

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BJP begins 'mission 2027' in UP with focus on 61 'weak' seats

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: The Bharatiya Janata Party has shifted fully into election mode in Uttar Pradesh, with the ruling party beginning groundwork for the 2027 Assembly elections nearly a year ahead of schedule. After the recent expansion of Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath's Cabinet, the party has now turned its attention towards strengthening its organisation and booth network across the state.

As part of its early strategy for the 2027 polls, the BJP will first focus on 61 assembly constituencies where the party has failed to register a victory in the last three consecutive assem-

bly elections held in 2012, 2017 and 2022.

According to party sources, Uttar Pradesh BJP president Pankaj Chaudhary has asked leaders to prioritise these difficult constituencies in the initial phase of the campaign exercise. The party plans to gather detailed electoral data, caste equations and booth-level feedback from these seats before preparing a constituency-wise roadmap to strengthen its presence on the ground.

Of the 61 constituencies identified by the BJP, 22 are located in eastern Uttar Pradesh, particularly in Azamgarh, Mau, Jaunpur, Ghazipur and Mirzapur districts. Around 13 such seats are in

western Uttar Pradesh, including constituencies in Saharanpur, Moradabad and Bijnor districts. Out of these 35 seats in eastern and western Uttar Pradesh, the Samajwadi Party had won 27 in the 2022 assembly elections. BJP leaders believe recent bypoll victories in Swar, Rampur and Kundiarki have boosted the party's confidence in regions earlier considered difficult terrain.

Among the remaining seats, three were won in 2022 by the Suheldev Bharatiya Samaj Party, now an ally of the BJP and part of the Yogi government. Two seats each were won by BJP allies Apna Dal (S) and the Nishad Party, while one seat went to the BSP.

NEW DELHI: Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Thursday emphasised the importance of fact-based debates on Thursday, stating that they not only strengthen constitutional institutions but also enhance their dignity and maintain public trust.

Birla made these remarks during the release of 89 volumes documenting the proceedings of the Central Legislative Assembly from 1924 to 1930 at the Delhi Assembly. He noted that this rare collection will serve as a valuable guide for the younger generation.

Accompanied by Union Minister of Parliamentary Affairs and Minority Affairs Kiren Rijiju, Delhi Assembly

Siddaramaiah: 'Janata' loyalist to Cong stalwart

Socialist roots to record-breaking CM, veteran leader reshaped K'taka politics

BENGALURU: For a man rooted in 'Janata Parivar' for over two decades and known for a strident anti-Congress stance in the past, it has been a remarkable turnaround for Siddaramaiah, who managed to consolidate his position in the grand old party and went on to become the longest-serving Chief Minister of Karnataka.

The 77-year-old senior Congress leader, who made no secret of his ambition to complete his tenure as chief minister and to sign off on a "high," was asked to resign two years ahead of the end of his term by the Congress high command to make way for a leadership change in the state.

During his second term as the CM, Siddaramaiah surpassed the record of Congress veteran and fellow Mysurian Devaraj Urs, becoming the longest-serving Chief Minister of Karnataka on January 7, reaching 2,792 days.

From the early 1980s to 2005, Siddaramaiah, who belonged to a poor farmer's family, was a die-hard anti-Congressman. However, his ouster from the former Prime Minister Deve Gowda-led JD



Siddaramaiah addresses a press conference after announcing his resignation, in Bengaluru, on Thursday

PTI

(S) brought him to a political crossroads, leading him to join in 2006, the very party he had opposed.

Siddaramaiah, an advocate, at one point in time talked about "political sanyas" and even toyed with the idea of going back to his law practice. He ruled out floating a regional outfit, saying he couldn't muster the money or power. Both the BJP and the Congress wooed him to join them. Siddaramaiah said he did not agree with the BJP's ideology and joined the Congress with his followers, a move con-

sidered "unthinkable" till then. A product of the 'Janata Parivar', he was influenced by the socialism advocated by Ram Manohar Lohia. He left his profession as an advocate to pursue a political career, starting as a taluk board member. In the Congress party, his patience and persistence paid off, and the seasoned politician, known for his bluntness, became Chief Minister in 2013, thus realising his lifetime ambition. Such qualities once again catapulted the nine-time MLA to the top position in 2023, after a five-year gap.

Key Points

» From the early 1980s to 2005, Siddaramaiah, who belonged to a poor farmer's family, was a die-hard anti-Congressman

» Siddaramaiah, an advocate, at one point in time talked about "political sanyas" and even toyed with the idea of going back to his law practice

» He ruled out floating a regional outfit, saying he couldn't muster the money or power

After the fractured verdict in 2004, the Congress and JD(S) formed a coalition government. Siddaramaiah, then in JD(S), became Deputy Chief Minister while N Dharam Singh of the Congress became Chief Minister. Siddaramaiah always held the grievance that he had the opportunity to become Chief Minister then, but Gowda scuttled his prospects.

Following this, in 2005, Siddaramaiah, a Kuruba -- the third largest caste in Karnataka -- chose to position himself as a backward classes leader, by

spearheading AHINDA (Kannada acronym for minorities, backward classes and Dalits) conventions, at a time when Deve Gowda's son H D Kumaraswamy was seen as a rising star of the JD(S).

He made his Assembly debut in 1983, and he was elected from Chamundeshwari constituency in Mysuru on a Lok Dal party ticket. He was the first Chairman of the 'Kannada Kavalu Samiti', a watchdog committee mandated to supervise the implementation of Kannada as the official language, formed during Ramakrishna Hegde's chief ministership. Later, he became the Sericulture Minister.

Born on August 12, 1948, at Siddaramanahundi, a village in Mysuru district, Siddaramaiah graduated from Mysore University with a BSc degree; later earned his Law degree from the same varsity, and practised law for some time. Siddaramaiah is married to Parvati and has a son, Dr Yathindra, a Congress MLC. His elder son, Rakesh, who was once considered his political heir apparent, died in 2016.

AGENCIES

PM Modi urges states to end water disputes amicably

Says resolve water issues through cooperation

NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi has asked states to resolve inter-state water disputes through cooperation, timely clearances and technology-based monitoring, and said the Ken-Betwa project should serve as a model.

Chairing the 51st PRAGATI meeting, where seven critical infrastructure projects across railways, power and road sectors covering nine states worth around Rs 30,000 crore were reviewed on Wednesday evening, he underlined that delay in implementation of public projects leads not only to cost escalation but also deprives citizens of timely access to essential facilities.

"During yesterday's PRAGATI session, projects worth over Rs 30,000 crore were reviewed. The works covered sectors like railways, power and road connectivity. Aspects relating to ports, Swachh Bharat Mission 2.0 and other social sector schemes were also



PM Narendra Modi chairs the 50th meeting of PRAGATI

PTI

discussed," Modi said in a post on X on Thursday.

While reviewing the Ken-Betwa river inter-linking project, the prime minister said it should serve as a model for other states to resolve inter-state water issues through cooperation, timely clearances, technology-based monitoring and mission-mode execution, an official statement said.

States were encouraged to identify similar opportunities where river-linking, water conservation, groundwater recharge and efficient irrigation can be taken up in an

integrated manner to ensure long-term water security, the statement said.

PRAGATI is an ICT-enabled, multi-modal platform aimed at fostering pro-active governance and timely implementation, by seamlessly integrating efforts of the central and state governments.

The seven critical infrastructure projects are pivotal to economic growth and public welfare and these were reviewed with a focus on timelines, inter-agency coordination, and timely issue resolution.

Om Birla unveils 89 'historical' volumes of Assembly proceedings



LS Speaker Om Birla during the launch

PTI

Speaker Vijender Gupta and Delhi Parliamentary Affairs Minister Parvash Sahib Singh, Birla also unveiled the inaugural issue of the assembly's magazine, 'Vidhan Chetna'.

In his address, Birla highlighted the significance of the Delhi Assembly building, where the Central Legislative

Assembly operated during British rule.

"It was from this very house that the fight for representative rights gained momentum and where several national leaders raised their voices against oppressive colonial laws through historic debates and discussions," Birla said.

MPOST

Ramesh says 'SIR' will influence future policymaking

KOZHIKODE: Senior Congress leader Jairam Ramesh on Thursday said SIR—sustainable, inclusive and rapid development—would be the dominant theme of policymaking in the coming years, irrespective of which party is in power.

Delivering the M P Veerendrakumar Memorial Lecture here, Ramesh said the country would face three major challenges over the next 10 to 15 years, which he termed as SIR, with 'S' standing for sustainable development, 'I' for inclusive development and 'R' for rapid development.

He said all three were important, as the country needed economic growth that was environmentally sustainable, inclusive in ensuring benefits reached all sections of society rather than a select few, and rapid enough to create jobs for the seven to eight million Indians entering the labour market every year.

The senior Congress leader said that irrespective of which party was in power at the Centre or in the states, the priority



in the coming years would be integrating the environment with development.

"Secondly, we have to create wealth, but ensure that inequalities do not widen. Thirdly, we have to expand the economy to create more and more jobs," he said.

The AICC general secretary in charge of communications also spoke about his close association with Veerendrakumar and recalled the latter's contributions.

Ramesh said he first met Veerendrakumar nearly 30 years ago after the latter was sworn in as Union Minister of State for Finance.

At the time, Ramesh was serving as an adviser to then Finance Minister P Chidambaram. "Over the years, till his death, we maintained a very close and cordial relationship," he said.

MPOST

'EDUCATION IS A POWERFUL BRIDGE'

Russia backs stronger academic ties with India

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: As India and Russia continue to deepen their longstanding strategic partnership spanning defence, energy, trade and technology, education is steadily emerging as a key pillar of bilateral cooperation. The Indo-Russian Education Summit, being held in New Delhi, reflects the growing importance of academic collaboration in strengthening ties between the two countries.

Discussions at the summit focused on the idea that education today goes beyond degrees and career advancement, serving as a powerful tool for building long-term people-to-people connections.

Addressing the summit on Thursday, Russian Ambassador Denis Alipov described education as "one of the most powerful instruments" for promoting cooperation and mutual understanding among nations. He said

HIGHLIGHTS

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» Russian Ambassador Denis Alipov described education as 'one of the most powerful instruments' for promoting cooperation and mutual understanding among nations

» The ambassador underlined the



strong educational ties between the two countries, particularly in medicine, engineering and technical education

academic engagement between India and Russia has evolved beyond conventional student exchanges into a broader partnership fostering scientific research, innovation and technological progress.

"It is no longer a question of whether international cooperation in education is necessary, but an obligation in an increasingly interconnected world," Alipov said, highlighting the need for collaboration in rap-

idly advancing sectors such as artificial intelligence, healthcare and science.

The ambassador underlined the strong educational ties between the two countries, particularly in medicine, engineering and technical education. Russian universities, he noted, continue to attract Indian students because of affordable tuition fees, advanced scientific infrastructure and reputed academic programmes.

According to education sector estimates, thousands of Indian students are currently pursuing studies in Russia, especially in medical institutions, making education one of the strongest people-to-people links between the two nations. Russia has also set a target of enrolling 500,000 international students by 2030.

"Universities create bridges that transcend geographical and political boundaries. Sci-

entists exchange ideas and young people gain exposure to different cultures," Alipov said, stressing the role of educational diplomacy in fostering global understanding.

Indian delegates at the summit echoed similar views and called for stronger collaboration between universities in both countries. They pointed to growing interest among Indian students in pursuing medical and technology education in Russia and discussed plans for joint academic programmes, faculty exchanges and collaborative research initiatives.

"This is much more than student admissions or mobility programmes. It is about building a comprehensive educational ecosystem between India and Russia," an Indian educator participating in the summit said.

Technological cooperation also featured prominently in the discussions, with both sides exploring joint research initia-

tives in artificial intelligence, engineering, healthcare technologies and innovation-driven development.

Against the backdrop of India's New Education Policy and Russia's expanding academic outreach, the summit is being seen as a significant step towards institutionalising educational cooperation as an integral part of bilateral relations. Beyond academics, such partnerships are expected to contribute to innovation, cultural understanding and the development of a globally skilled workforce.

The summit concluded with renewed emphasis on institutional partnerships, student exchange programmes and fresh initiatives to strengthen academic cooperation, reaffirming that while governments shape strategic partnerships, they are ultimately sustained through students, researchers and educational institutions.

Regional parties' income falls 52% in FY25: ADR report

'21 spent more than their earnings'

MPOST BUREAU

INSIGHT

» The highest income was declared by the TDP at Rs 228.31 crore

» It was followed closely by the AITC at Rs 219.35 cr and the YSR Congress at Rs 140.39 crore

NEW DELHI: The combined income of 36 regional political parties declined by over 51 per cent in 2024-25 compared to the previous financial year, while 21 of them spent more than their declared earnings, according to a report by the Association for Democratic Reforms (ADR).

The report, released on May 27, analysed the audited accounts of 36 out of 67 recognised regional parties whose annual audit reports for the financial year 2024-25 were available on the Election Commission website. It noted that the remaining 31 parties had not made their audit reports available even 207 days after the October 31, 2025, deadline.

According to the ADR's analysis, the total income of the 36 regional parties stood at Rs 1,192.94 crore in the FY 2024-25, down from Rs 2,463.17 crore in FY 2023-24, a decline of Rs 1,270.23 crore or 51.57 per cent. The total expenditure declared by these parties, however, reached Rs 1,433.07 crore, exceeding their combined income by Rs 240.12 crore or about 20 per cent.

The report said the top five parties accounted for nearly 69 per cent of the total income and over 77 per cent of total expenditure among the parties analysed.

Among regional parties, the highest income was declared by the Telugu Desam Party (TDP) at Rs 228.31 crore, constituting 19.14 per cent of the total income, followed closely by the All India Trinamool Congress (AITC) at Rs 219.35 crore and the YSR Congress at Rs 140.39 crore. On the expenditure front, YSR Congress spent the most at Rs 340.20 crore, followed

by Biju Janata Dal (BJD) at Rs 288.44 crore and AITC at Rs 227.59 crore.

The ADR report highlighted that 21 of the 36 parties spent more than the income they collected during the year.

YSR Congress recorded the highest excess expenditure, spending Rs 199.82 crore more than its income, amounting to 142.33 per cent above its earnings. Parties such as AITC, BRS, BJD, JD(U) and SP also reported expenditure exceeding their income.

At the same time, 15 parties reported unspent income. The TDP had the largest surplus, retaining Rs 166.98 crore unspent, followed by Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS) with Rs 36.27 crore and AIADMK with Rs 35.86 crore.

Voluntary contributions remained the biggest source of funding for regional parties. Donations and contributions accounted for Rs 702.36 crore or 58.88 per cent of total income. The AITC reported the highest donations at Rs 184.08 crore, followed by YSR Congress at Rs 140.05 crore and TDP at Rs 85.20 crore. Interest income contributed another Rs 277.21 crore, or 23.24 per cent of the total income.

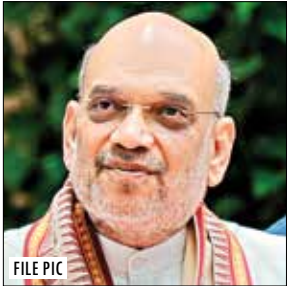
The report further observed that election expenditure and administrative expenses remained the most common spending heads.

'Panel on demographic changes to also assess need for new law'

MPOST BUREAU

GANDHINAGAR: Union Home minister Amit Shah on Thursday said the Centre's high-level committee on "artificial" demographic changes due to illegal immigration and other unnatural causes will also assess whether a law is required to tackle the issue.

Speaking at a gathering after inaugurating and laying the foundation stone for development projects worth Rs 340 crore, Shah said the committee, headed by retired Supreme Court judge Justice Prakash Prabhakar Naolekar, would submit its report within a year. A notification issued by the Union Ministry of Home Affairs on Wednesday on the constitution of the High-Level Committee on Demographic Changes



(HLCDC) said that "extensive challenges" have arisen from demographic changes due to illegal immigration.

"The high-powered committee will examine the causes behind the artificial demographic shifts that have occurred across the nation. It will deliberate on the remedial measures required, and, should the enactment of any

Shah said the panel, headed by retired SC judge Justice Prakash Prabhakar Naolekar, would submit its report within a year

specific legislation be necessary, it will address that requirement as well," Shah said.

The Centre was determined to identify and expel every "ghuspathiya" or infiltrator from the country, he said, adding that Prime Minister Narendra Modi decided to constitute the demographic change committee with this objective.

Diversion of homebuyers' funds: SC seeks responses from ED, RBI

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court has sought responses from the Centre, ED, RBI and others, including a few real estate firms, on a plea alleging that thousands of crores collected from homebuyers in Noida and Yamuna Expressway projects were siphoned off.

A bench comprising Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and justices Joyymalya Bagchi and Vipul M Pancholi on Wednesday took note of the submissions of lawyer Prashant Bhushan, appearing for petitioner Vandana Sabharwal, and issued notices to respondents for July 15.

Besides Union ministries of housing and urban affairs and corporate affairs, ED and the RBI, the bench also sought responses of the Uttar Pradesh RERA (Real

Estate Regulation and Development Authority), Noida Authority, Yamuna Expressway Industrial Development Authority (YEIDA), Jaiprakash Associates Ltd (JAL), Jaiprakash Infratech Ltd (JIL), Standard Chartered Bank, and developers including CRC Homes, CRC Greens, Gaursons, Gulshan Homz, Mahagun and Investors Clinic. Sabharwal, in her plea, said that the case reflected a larger systemic pattern in the real estate sector where developers allegedly divert homebuyers' funds, transfer land and development rights to related entities, and eventually push projects into insolvency, leaving buyers stranded.

Bhushan referred to findings of the ED, which is investigat-

ing the matter under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA). He told the bench that the ED had found that out of nearly Rs 14,559 crore collected by JAL and JIL from over 25,000 homebuyers, "substantial amounts" were diverted for non-construction purposes and siphoned off to related group entities, including Jaypee group companies.

"This issue keeps recurring project after project," Bhushan said. "Funds are collected from homebuyers, diverted elsewhere, and the companies eventually go into bankruptcy. Homeowners are left in a serious situation because the diverted funds are either never identified, or not identified and brought back in time," he said.

MPOST

Horticulture key to farmers' prosperity: Haryana CM

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Crop diversification and horticulture-based farming are key to farmers' prosperity, Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini said on Thursday as he suggested several measures to increase the horticulture sector's output in the state.

Addressing a national conference on "Strategic Paradigm of Quality Seeds and Planting Material for Horticultural Crops" organised by Maharana Pratap Horticulture University, Karnal, and the Lieutenant Amit Memorial Foundation, Saini announced several initiatives aimed at strengthening the horticulture sector in the state. The Chief Minister dedicated 14 new horticulture science centres to the university and announced the launch of Master's and PhD programmes in emerging subjects such as post-harvest man-



agement, plant pest control and diseases. He said the centres would provide farmers with modern technologies, quality planting material and scientific guidance.

Saini said India is the world's second-largest producer of fruits and vegetables, generating over 360 million tonnes of horticultural produce annually. Despite this achievement, the country suffers economic losses due to poor grading systems, inadequate post-harvest management and lack of disease-free planting

Saini flags off 80 electric buses

CHANDIGARH: Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Thursday inaugurated an electric bus depot in Panipat and flagged off 80 electric city buses.

On this occasion, Saini said that a new era of clean, modern and environment-friendly transport has begun in Haryana from the historic and sacred land of Panipat.

He said that out of the 80 electric buses flagged off on Thursday, 40 buses have been allocated for Panipat, 15 for Yamunanagar, 10 each for Kurukshetra and Sonapat, and 5 for Panchkula. He said these are not merely buses, but the beginning of a clean, convenient and modern future for Haryana.

The chief minister said that a state-of-the-art electric bus depot has been developed in Panipat at a cost of about Rs 7 crore. Besides this, electric bus depots are under construction in 8 other districts of the state, where modern charging facilities for buses will also be provided.

MPOST

material. He said quality seeds and planting material could increase agricultural productivity by 15 to 25 per cent, making scientific management and modern supply chains essential for the sector's growth.

Highlighting Haryana gov-

ernment initiatives, Saini said protected prices have been fixed for 21 horticultural crops under the Bhavantar Bharpai Yojana. He added that the state has set a target to double the horticulture sector and triple production by 2030.

Right to trauma care of citizens an integral part of right to life: SC

NEW DELHI: Observing that right to trauma care of citizens is an integral part of right to life, the Supreme Court has asked all states and Union territories to operationalise within three months one helpline number '112' for emergency responses and establish functional good samaritan grievance redressal system.

A bench of Justices J K Maheshwari and A S Chandurkar also directed the states to furnish periodic compliance reports by organising monthly meetings and uploading the minutes on the concerned portals. The bench passed the order on Tuesday on a plea filed by Savelife Foundation which raised the need for trauma care to be recognised as a matter of right in the Indian public law system. The top court said when a person suffers an accident or any such similar incident which requires urgent trauma care, they usually feel shock and disorientation, a sense of helplessness where they have to hope that those around them would somehow help them get the care that they need.

"In such a situation, every minute spent without medical intervention or urgent care significantly narrows the scope for survival. Swiftly, it is quite literally, like medicine," it said.

Referring to different stages of care after such an incident, the bench said a robust mechanism for trauma care must take a "bottom-up approach" which accounts for various stakeholders. It said usually, no matter how strong the urge to be a good samaritan is, the bystander hesitates, suffers a reactive paralysis, sometimes due to fear of legal proceedings, of getting summoned to police station as a witness and sometimes due to the psychological weight of the situation itself.

It permitted the Centre to issue a medical rescue protocol for trauma cases within three months, and directed all the states and UTs to operationalise the same within three months thereof. The bench asked the Union Health and Family Welfare ministry to issue guidelines prescribing the requisite data format for a trauma registry within eight weeks.

AGENCIES

FROM COLLEGE CANTEENS TO POLITICAL CORRIDORS

Bashir Badr: Urdu poet whose words travelled 'far beyond' literary circles

NEW DELHI: Bashir Badr, one of Urdu poetry's most relevant voices whose words reflected the complexity of life and politics, leaves behind a legacy that travelled far beyond literary circles and found their way into everyday conversations, political speeches and popular culture.

Badr, who died at his Bhopal home at the age of 91, had stepped away from the limelight several years ago following the onset of dementia. But his poetry drew the Badr name out of the shadows.

Born on February 15, 1935, in Faizabad (now Ayodhya), he was just seven when he started writing poetry. One of his most cited couplets -- "Ujale apni yaadon ke hamare saath rehne do, Na jaane kis gali mein zindagi ki shaam ho jaye..." -- was penned when he was a teen. Known for the use of highly contemporary Urdu in his ghazals, Badr brought conversational simplicity and emotional range to poetry that painted love, loneli-



ness, separation, and human relationships in a language that was both accessible and familiar all the way from political corridors to college canteens.

From reels to social media posts and from old fashioned letters to movies, the words went out. Writer and lyricist Varun Grover used Badr's couplet in the much appreciated 2015 film "Masaan". Another Badr admirer is filmmaker Vishal Bhardwaj who used Badr extensively in "Dedh Ishqiya".

In 2018, Badr's words echoed in the Lok Sabha.

Congress leader Mallikarjun Kharge quoted the Urdu poet and said, "Dushmani jamkar karo lekin ye gunjaish rahe, jab kabhi hum dost ho jayen toh sharminda naa ho." It's a couplet Badr is believed to have written after the Shimla Agreement in 1972. Prime Minister Narendra Modi also quoted Badr in his reply. "Jee bahut chahta hai sach bole, kya karein haunsa nahi hota."

Life for the prominent voice of contemporary India was not easy. In April 1987, Badr, who was then head of the Urdu department at

KEY POINTS

» Badr, who died at his Bhopal home at the age of 91, had stepped away from the limelight several years ago following the onset of dementia

» Born on February 15, 1935, in Faizabad (now Ayodhya), he was just seven when he started writing poetry

Meerut College, lost all his belongings, unpublished manuscripts and a library in the flames of a communal riot. Heartbroken, he left the city to settle in Bhopal where he lived till his last breath.

The pain of losing a home remained with him and spilled on to the paper when he wrote: "Log toot jaate hain ghar banane mein/Tum taras nahin khaate bastiyaan jalaane mein."

Badr received the Padma Shri award in 1999 and the Sahitya Akademi Award in Urdu for his poetry collection "Aas" in 1999.

AGENCIES



EDITORIAL
CARE WITHOUT
DELAY

The Supreme Court's recognition of trauma care as an integral part of the right to life under Article 21 is a necessary reminder that survival after an accident cannot depend on luck, geography or the courage of a passer-by. In a country where road crashes kill with grim regularity, the difference between life and death is often not the severity of the injury alone, but the speed and quality of response. By directing states and Union territories to operationalise a single emergency number, 112, within three months, and by requiring functional Good Samaritan grievance redressal systems, the Court has pushed India to confront a truth long visible on its roads: the victim of a crash is frequently abandoned by the system before reaching a hospital. The order, passed on a plea by SaveLIFE Foundation, rightly treats trauma care not as charity or administrative kindness, but as a constitutional obligation. India recorded 1,72,890 road accident deaths in 2023, higher than 1,68,491 in 2022, according to the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways. Young adults aged 18 to 45 accounted for 66.4 per cent of the fatalities, making road trauma not only a public health crisis but also a national productivity loss.

The Court's most important intervention lies in its insistence on a uniform, time-bound framework. India's emergency response remains fragmented between multiple numbers, uneven ambulance networks, poorly equipped vehicles, delayed police-medical coordination and inadequate public awareness. The directive to integrate helplines into 112 can reduce confusion in the critical moments after a crash, when a victim, bystander or family member does not have the luxury of figuring out which number works in which state. The Court has also asked for AIS-125 compliance across public and private ambulances, GPS or vehicle location tracking, real-time integration with helpline 112, structured audits of response times, quality of care, equipment and outcomes, and compliance reporting to a designated Union-level authority. These are not mere technical details. They are the skeleton of an emergency-care state. A helpline without ambulances is a slogan; an ambulance without trained personnel and equipment is only transport; and a protocol without audits becomes another forgotten file.

The Good Samaritan question is equally central. India's roads are full of witnesses, but too often short of helpers. Bystanders hesitate because they fear police harassment, legal entanglement, repeated summons, hospital formalities or blame. The law has tried to address this. Section 134A of the Motor Vehicles Act gives statutory protection to Good Samaritans, and earlier Supreme Court directions had already sought to shield helpers from unnecessary questioning and procedural harassment. Yet the gap between legal protection and street-level confidence remains wide. That is why the Court's direction for a grievance redressal system matters. A citizen who helps an accident victim must know that the state will protect him, not punish him with inconvenience. Public campaigns in multiple languages are also essential. Good Samaritan protections cannot remain buried in government notifications. They must be taught in schools, displayed in hospitals, announced in driving centres, carried on toll plazas and repeated through radio, television, social media and local administration. In trauma care, the first responder is often not a doctor but an ordinary citizen.

The order also points to deeper reform through trauma registries and medical rescue protocols. At present, India does not have a sufficiently strong, uniform and publicly accountable data system that tracks what happens after a crash: how long the ambulance took, whether first aid was provided, which hospital received the patient, whether cashless treatment was denied, whether the victim survived, and where the system failed. The Court has asked the Union Health Ministry to prescribe the data format for a trauma registry and states to establish registries covering medical facilities. This is crucial because without data, policy remains anecdotal. India must know not merely how many crashes occur, but how many deaths were preventable. The direction to operationalise PM RAHAT, the cashless treatment scheme for road accident victims, is equally significant. Families should not be forced into arguments over payment when every minute is medically precious. The principle must be simple: treatment first, paperwork later. SaveLIFE Foundation has long argued that timely assistance within the first few minutes and transport within the "golden hour" can significantly improve survival prospects.

The challenge now is implementation. India has a long record of well-intentioned judicial and policy interventions weakening at the level of district administration, hospital reception desks and police stations. The Supreme Court has done well to insist on monthly meetings, uploaded minutes and periodic compliance reports, because transparency is the only way to prevent this order from becoming symbolic. But states must go beyond formal compliance. They must map accident hotspots, station ambulances intelligently, train police and paramedics, ensure emergency departments cannot refuse victims, and build trauma networks linking highways, district hospitals, medical colleges and specialised centres. Road safety itself must improve, but when prevention fails, rescue must not. The right to life cannot end at the moment of impact. It must extend to the ambulance call, the bystander's protection, the hospital gate, the emergency ward and the follow-up record. The Supreme Court has given India a constitutional framework for trauma care. Governments must now convert that framework into saved lives.

IDLE
TREASURE



MITALI MADHUSMITA
THE WRITER IS A RETIRED IRS OFFICER WHO SERVED AS THE PRINCIPAL CHIEF COMMISSIONER OF INCOME TAX IN ANDHRA PRADESH AND TELANGANA

India imports almost all of its gold demand, while vast private reserves remain locked in households and religious institutions

When asked by his sidekick, Robert, about his three most favourite things, the quintessential villain of Bollywood, Ajit, says, "Mona, sona aur Mona ke haath mein sona." This dialogue sums up the average Indian's attitude towards gold. Post the Hormuz stand-off and the critical balance of payments situation, the Prime Minister of our country has made an extraordinary appeal to his countrymen to avoid non-essential purchase of gold over the next one year — no mean task for the average Indian. The sentimental attachment to gold is not just confined to India. The glitter of gold has manifested itself the world over since time immemorial, while it has also spelt doom for mankind. Since its discovery, gold has been both the epitome as well as the bane of civilised society. Ancient civilisations in Rome, India, Egypt, China, etc., greatly valued gold. Ancient Egyptian pharaohs were buried with gold to ensure divinity in the afterlife. Internal organs were stored in four "canopic jars" placed inside an elaborate chest. The boy-king Tutankhamun was buried in a gilded shrine, flanked by four solid gold miniature coffins holding his organs. In China, elite tombs from the Shang and Han Dynasties often contained gold-leaf-coated lacquers, solid gold ornaments, and gold masks over the deceased.

In India, gold moved from association with divinity and the elite to a common man's obsession. Goddess Lakshmi is depicted with multiple arms in Abhaya mudra, denoting benevolence, peace and prosperity, and notably, one arm has gold coins literally falling off her palms in a steady stream. By the turn of the common era, the Romans were calling India the Golden Sparrow, or *some ki chidiya*. Pliny the Elder, writer, naturalist, commander of the Roman forces and a friend of Emperor Vespasian, lamented that Romans were importing unproductive luxuries which were not worth the gold Rome was giving up, and that their luxuries and women were costing them one million sesterces, or Roman coins, per year. This also meant that India's wealth attracted looters and



India must find ways to convert its vast idle gold reserves into productive national capital

plunderers. Mahmud of Ghazni attacked and plundered India no less than 17 times. Thus began the waves of invasion that the country went through.

The lure of the yellow metal has led a lot of men to their graves. Recall the gold mining craze in the US, Canada, Australia, Venezuela, Brazil and South Africa, just prior to the Industrial Revolution, where unsafe mining and territorial battles led to a great many deaths. However, the resulting increase in the world's gold supply did stimulate global trade and investment. There is an entire body of historical data about the mass migration, trade, colonisation and environmental history associated with gold rushes. Highly significant to their respective colonies' political and economic development, each wave brought many immigrants and promoted massive government spending on infrastructure to support the new arrivals who came looking for gold. While some found their fortune, those who did not often remained in the colonies and took advantage of extremely liberal land laws to take up farming.

Gold is a natural mineral mined from the earth. It has no intrinsic great looks, yet it is greatly treasured around the world. Historically, gold has been a common form of money as it is relatively easy to carry,

measure and verify for impurities. Its value as the most treasured form of money dipped slightly ever since the USA, and consequently the world, delinked it from dollar convertibility and moved from a hybrid gold standard to fiat currency, i.e., the dollar. However, most central banks continue to hold a substantial portion of their reserves in the form of gold, the US Treasury being the highest holder. Gold is not just commodity money due to its intrinsic value, but also a tangible sentiment. People refer to the gold standard as a benchmark for excellence in different fields. A gold standard is a specific type of benchmark considered the absolute best-in-class, definitive reference, or the ideal target that all others strive to achieve. To give an example, you test a new AI model against a standardised question set, or benchmark, and compare its accuracy against human expert judgment, or gold standard.

Coming to present-day India, almost all gold is imported, with less than 1 per cent of demand met locally. In comparison, China mines 19 per cent of the total gold. The continued obsession with gold comes at a cost. Despite the RBI having accumulated stocks approximating USD 1.49 trillion, gold imports continue to be

more than Rs 2.5 trillion a year, about 9 per cent of India's total value of imports, contributing to the deficit on the external account. This is perhaps an opportune time to revisit the existing schemes for monetisation of idle reserves, estimated between 23,000 and 24,000 tonnes by households and religious institutions by WGC in 2016, and come up with new gold-backed financial products to unlock the hidden potential of gold.

The Gold Monetisation Scheme (GMS), introduced in the Budget of 2015, needs strengthening by the inclusion of more bank branches, smaller, say 1 gm gold, deposits in rural areas and a more attractive rate of interest. A nudge approach by the government and banks, targeting not just individuals but also temples and trusts, and spelling out the pros of the scheme, can be helpful. A Gold Board as a one-stop interface responsible for policies, Gold Domestic Councils, linked to State Gold Forums to offer a unified forum for domestic gold manufacturers, and a Bullion Exchange under the Ministry of Finance to offer a regulated marketplace for price discovery, quality assurance and traceability of transactions, have been proposed by the Niti Aayog report, 'Transforming India's Gold Market', of 2018.

Among other measures suggested by Niti Aayog were the Sovereign Gold Bonds Scheme, Gold Savings Accounts and the Gold Metal Loan Scheme (GML), the latter being intrinsically linked to the performance of GMS. Gold mining can be made attractive for investors with top-class refining facilities. Tax reforms on import and manufacturing, tie-ups with world-renowned design institutes, and appropriate skill development that encourages MSMEs to export using B2C were other suggestions. At the end of the day, sound and well-conceived innovative policies for monetisation of gold that appeal to public consciousness, businesses and capital are required. Only when it reaches a critical mass can the potential of gold be gainfully harnessed. The country must be mindful of its history and nurture both the goose and the golden eggs it lays.

Views expressed are personal

UNEQUAL
BURDEN



AMAL CHANDRA
THE WRITER IS A POLICY ANALYST AND A COLUMNIST

From construction sites and farms to cramped homes, workshops and classrooms, high temperatures are reducing concentration, cutting work hours and deepening inequality

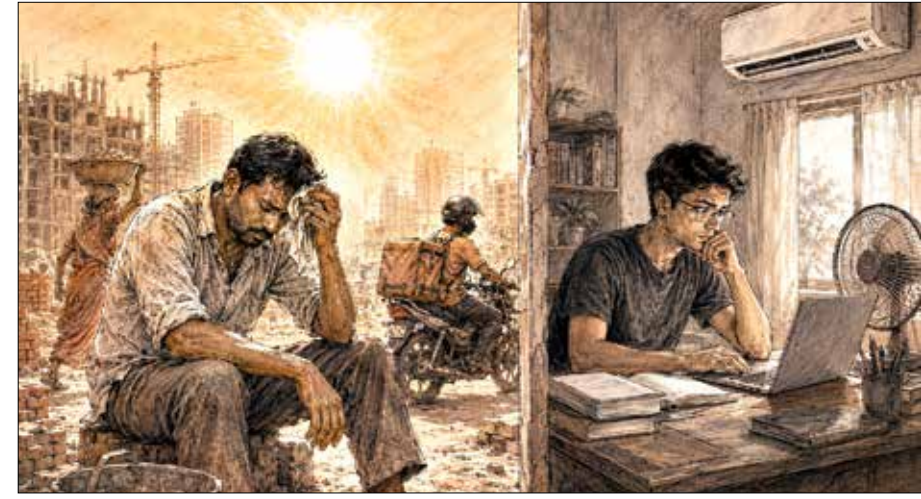
India often discusses productivity as though it were purely a matter of discipline, skills, incentives or infrastructure. Economists debate labour reforms. Managers speak of efficiency. Governments promote digitalisation. Yet one of the most immediate and rapidly worsening barriers to productivity at this period is more elemental: heat.

When temperatures rise sharply, concentration drops, fatigue sets in faster, errors increase, tempers shorten and working hours shrink. For millions whose jobs require physical exertion outdoors or in poorly ventilated spaces, heat is not an inconvenience. It is a hard ceiling on output. For students, freelancers and small entrepreneurs, it can turn a normal workday into a battle of endurance. Productivity, in other words, is linked not only to policy or talent, but to the environment. And India's environment is getting harsher.

This matters because India's workforce is unusually exposed. Large numbers of people work in agriculture, construction, transport, street vending, warehousing, manufacturing workshops and informal services. Many operate in conditions with little cooling, unreliable electricity, sheet-metal roofs, concrete heat traps or long commutes under direct sun. Even those in offices are not always protected: power cuts, crowded public transport and overheated homes reduce performance before the workday begins.

The science is straightforward. Human beings regulate body temperature within narrow limits, so when heat and humidity rise the body diverts energy toward cooling itself, causing fluid loss, higher heart rate, weaker cognitive performance, reduced physical capacity and a greater need for breaks, with extreme cases leading to heat exhaustion or heatstroke, making these biological stressors direct economic burdens.

Recent global research has sharpened the picture. Heat stress affects labour supply, labour productivity and labour capacity through both



Heat is not merely an inconvenience. For millions of workers, it is a hard ceiling on output

physiological and behavioural responses. The International Labour Organisation has similarly warned that excessive heat threatens worker safety, incomes and decent work standards.

For India, the stakes are especially high. Heatwaves have become more frequent, longer and more geographically widespread. The summers of recent years have been among the harshest in recent memory, with many regions recording prolonged temperatures above 40°C. Heat stress in India is not confined to headline-grabbing northern heatwaves; coastal humidity, urban heat islands and night-time temperatures are creating stress across regions.

The hidden dimension is what happens indoors after the headlines fade.

A college student preparing for exams in a single-room home with poor ventilation is less productive than a peer in an air-conditioned apartment, while a young jobseeker filling applications on a lagging phone in a sweltering room begins at a disadvantage even before the interview; a delivery worker may return from the sun too exhausted to study for an upskilling course, a tailor in a tin-roof workshop can lose hours each afternoon because the room becomes unbearable, and a writer, coder or designer without cooling ends up spending mental energy merely staying functional. This is where

inequality enters the story.

Those with money increasingly buy relief: air-conditioners, insulated housing, backup power, quieter workspaces, memberships at cafés, co-working hubs and private reading rooms. Those without money absorb the cost through lost concentration, lower output, interrupted sleep and poorer health. Heat thus acts as a regressive tax on ambition.

Not everyone can afford cafés or paid reading rooms, yet in many Indian cities these spaces have become informal offices and study centres because they provide seating, electricity, internet and cooling—basic substitutes for missing public infrastructure in a heat-stressed economy. But they remain exclusionary: daily café bills are unaffordable for many, reading-room fees burden students already paying coaching costs, travel adds time and expense, women may face safety or mobility barriers, and smaller towns often lack such options entirely. If productivity increasingly depends on access to cool, quiet and connected spaces, then productivity is becoming purchasable. India should recognise this not as a private lifestyle choice, but as a public policy challenge.

Consider libraries. Many public libraries remain underfunded, outdated or poorly maintained. Yet globally, libraries are among the most demo-

cratic productivity institutions ever built: free seating, silence, electricity, books, increasingly internet access, and protection from the weather. In a hotter India, the humble library deserves reinvention as a climate-resilient civic workspace. Cities and states should modernise public libraries, keep them open longer during peak exam seasons, provide reliable cooling and fans, add charging points, improve sanitation and create dedicated study zones. Where library networks are thin, municipalities can convert unused buildings into seasonal study halls during summer months.

Similarly, community cooling centres need not be emergency-only spaces activated during disasters. They can double as daytime work and study centres in heatwave months, especially in dense low-income neighbourhoods. Schools, panchayat halls, ward offices and community centres can be adapted for this purpose.

Workplaces also need to change. Heat action plans too often focus narrowly on mortality, which is vital but incomplete. Productivity loss deserves equal attention. Governments should encourage staggered shifts, shaded rest areas, hydration stations, mandatory cooling breaks for outdoor labour, better ventilation standards and heat-safe building design. Contractors who rely on man-

ual labour should be required to adjust schedules away from peak afternoon heat.

Urban design matters as much as labour law. Trees, shaded bus stops, reflective roofs, water access, parks and cooler pavements all influence how drained people are before they even begin work. A commuter who arrives less exhausted is a more productive worker. A student who sleeps better because night-time temperatures are lower will learn more the next day.

There is also a macroeconomic dimension that is often understated. If heat steadily cuts effective working hours, weakens learning outcomes and increases illness, it will suppress growth and quietly erode India's demographic dividend, which depends not just on a young population, but on one able to work and think efficiently. International institutions have warned that rising temperatures could sharply reduce global work hours, with South Asia among the most exposed. India cannot assume its GDP ambitions will remain untouched by climate realities. Technology can help through remote work, better forecasting and cheaper cooling, but if access remains private, the underlying inequality will persist.

A serious national response must treat heat as an economic productivity challenge, not merely a disaster issue: by ensuring universal access to cool public work and study spaces, strengthening labour protections for heat-exposed workers, redesigning cities for shade and ventilation, and improving data on heat-related productivity, absenteeism and educational losses. Above all, India must reject the illusion that resilience can be bought privately. When performance depends on access to air-conditioning, café tables or private rooms, society becomes climate-stratified rather than meritocratic. India's next productivity leap may come not from slogans or apps, but from enabling every citizen to think, learn and work in humane conditions.

Views expressed are personal

LEBANESE AND ISRAELI OFFICIALS

Israeli strikes kill 14 across southern Lebanon ahead of Washington talks

BEIRUT: The Israeli military early Thursday pounded Lebanon's fourth-largest city, killing at least 14 people across the south of the country in its ongoing military escalation against the Hezbollah group ahead of crucial talks in Washington.

Among those killed in the flurry of strikes were five women and children and a Lebanese soldier. Dozens of others were wounded, according to the Lebanese Health Ministry and the state-run National News Agency.

An Israeli soldier meanwhile was killed in a Hezbollah drone attack in northern Israel, the Israeli military said.

The intensification comes after Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu announced an expansion in the Israeli military's attacks in Lebanon, apparently sparked by Hezbollah's use of fibre-optic exploding drones that have struck Israeli troops in Lebanon and reached some of Israel's northern border towns.



A woman near the rubble of her home destroyed in an Israeli airstrike in the southern village of Maarakeh, Lebanon

Lebanese and Israeli military officials are set to hold their first security talks on Friday in the US capital. The talks have extended a nominal ceasefire that went into effect April 17, although the attacks have since intensified, while sparing the Lebanese capital Beirut.

Hezbollah has dismissed the talks and instead endorsed its key ally Iran, which has made ending the war in Lebanon a condition for its own talks with Washington brokered by Pakistan.

Before the attacks on Thursday, Israeli military Arabic spokesperson Avichay Adraee issued warnings to eight build-

Highlights

- » Victims included five women and children, a Lebanese soldier, and displaced civilians sheltering in buildings
- » An Israeli soldier was killed and two reservists wounded in a Hezbollah drone attack in Israel
- » A separate strike in Adloun killed six members of a fleeing family

ings in the coastal city of Tyre along the Mediterranean and surrounding neighborhoods. Many people have fled the area.

Further north in the city of Sidon, an Israeli drone struck an apartment building where some displaced families lived, killing five people and wounding 21 others, among them five children. Among the killed

was Hossan Zeidan who once was a correspondent for Iran's Arabic-language al-Aalam television. Mohammad Al-Gharbi, who lived across the street from the building in Sidon, woke to the sound of the explosion. "I was in my room when part of the wall and shattered glass fell on me, and everything was thrown into chaos," he said. "This building that was hit had six apartments occupied by poor families who had fled from the south to escape the attacks there, only to be hit here." In the nearby coastal town of Adloun, an Israeli drone struck a car with a family that was fleeing, killing six people, of which four were two children and their parents, the Lebanese Health Ministry said. Another drone strike that came without warning killed two people on a motorcycle near Tyre. The target of the attack was not immediately clear, NNA reported.

AGENCIES



Palestinians offer Eid al-Adha prayers beside the ruins of a mosque destroyed by Israeli bombardment, in Khan Younis

AP/PTI

body wrapped in a white shroud with a Hamas flag draped over it. His death came as a "shock" to the family, even though they knew it could happen at any time, his cousin Nidal Isleim said.

The strikes came as Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said on Thursday that Israel was expanding its control in Gaza.

"Right now we are tightening the grip on Hamas," Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said Thursday at a conference in Jordan. "We are

now in 60% of the territory of the Gaza Strip. You know that? We were at 50%, we moved to 60%."

He said the next step was to move to 70% control, with Israel "tightening the grip" on Hamas "from every direction."

"We will deal with the remnants," Netanyahu said. "But the most important thing is to continue leveraging our power, to increase it."

The conference was part of a broader discussion on the war, Iran, Hezbollah, Gaza and regional strategy.

AGENCIES

Kenya: Fire at girl's school dormitory kills at least 16

GILGIL (Kenya): A fire ripped through a dormitory in a girls' boarding school in central Kenya on Thursday, killing at least 16 students, a government official said, in the latest such incident to afflict the East African nation.

Education Minister Julius Ogamba said Thursday that 79 others were injured at the Utumishi Girls School, which has more than 800 students in the Gilgil area of central Kenya.

The cause has not yet been established. Ogamba said authorities would investigate whether the school's fire safety manual had been adhered to.

Police said they were leading the rescue and emergency response efforts at the school, which is located about 120 kilometres from the capital, Nairobi.

The government-owned secondary school is managed and sponsored by the Kenya Police Service. Many of the students are daughters of police officers.

The victims have not yet been identified.

One person at the scene, Wambui Nderitu, arrived to check on her cousin, who is a student at the school. She said she heard that the matron opened one of two dormitory doors "without alerting the children to exit."

"The second door remained closed, and even though my cousin escaped with a leg injury, we've been told many children are injured and some died," Nderitu said.

The Kenya Red Cross said several students were evacuated and are receiving treatment in various hospitals.

The group said it deployed "tracing and psychosocial support teams to support affected students and families."

Kenya's deadliest school fire in recent history occurred in 2001 when 67 students died in a dormitory fire in Machakos County.

AGENCIES

Drones hit 3 'shadow fleet' oil tankers off Turkiye coast

ISTANBUL: Three oil tankers were attacked by drones Thursday off Turkey's Black Sea coast, a shipping agency said.

The ships all appear on Western sanctions lists as part of a "shadow fleet" exporting Russian oil and petroleum products and evading Western sanctions on Moscow because of its war in Ukraine. One was previously targeted in March.

Tribeca Shipping said the Palau-flagged ship James II was sailing 80 kilometres (50 miles) north of Turkeli district in Sinop when it was attacked. It was not carrying any cargo.

The Altura and Velora, both flagged to Sierra Leone, were targeted while carrying out ship-to-ship operations in a nearby area, according to a statement from the agency cited by Turkish media. The crews of all three ships were unharmed.

AGENCIES

EMPTY BOWLS



Palestinians wait to receive donated food at a distribution center in Khan Younis

AP/PTI

Netanyahu aide to face charges over classified leak

NAHARIYA (Israel): Israel's attorney general on Thursday said a close adviser to Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu will face criminal prosecution for leaking secret information to a German newspaper with the intent of harming the country's security. The announcement marked another scandal for the embattled Netanyahu as the country gears up for elections this fall. Netanyahu himself is on trial for corruption in three separate cases and faces tensions within his coalition that threaten to dissolve parliament.

The attorney general's office said it plans to indict Jonatan Urich in the leak of a classified document in 2024 to a German tabloid that critics said was aimed to help absolve Netanyahu of blame for failed negotiations with Hamas during the war in Gaza. It said Urich would also be charged with possession of confidential information and destruction of evidence.

Netanyahu's office refused to comment on the planned indictment. But Urich's lawyers told Israel's Army Radio channel that the decision was "wrong and disconnected from the evidence."

Urich reacted with a sarcastic one-line post on social media, saying "It's quite something that the AG didn't ask for a death sentence."

Netanyahu and members of his inner circle have claimed they are the victims of a politically motivated witch hunt by overzealous prosecutors and the media. The attorney general's office did not say when the indictment would be officially handed down.

AGENCIES

Pressing US for more Patriot missiles for Ukr to counter Russian strikes: Zelenskyy

KYIV: Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Thursday that he's being "very persistent" in pressing the United States to provide his country with more Patriot air defence missiles that can counter devastating Russian ballistic missile attacks.

Zelenskyy said he hasn't yet received a reply to a letter he sent earlier this week to US President Donald Trump and Congress asking for more of the American-made ammunition. He warned that deliveries to Ukraine are falling dangerously short as the Iran war diverts and depletes US stocks.

Zelenskyy is keen to secure more deliveries of foreign weaponry that it can't produce itself

"I believe (the US) must act quicker. We are being very persistent," Zelenskyy told reporters during a visit to Sweden.

Zelenskyy is keen to secure more deliveries of foreign weaponry that it can't produce itself as it battles Russia's full-scale invasion, which began on Feb. 24, 2022. In exchange, he's offer-

ing to share the cutting-edge drone expertise that Ukraine has built up during the war. Russia has used its long-range ballistic missiles to damage Ukraine's power grid and hammer cities.

The Ukrainian capital is bracing for further heavy bombardments. But no foreign diplomats are known to have heeded Moscow's recommendation to leave Kyiv before what the Russian Foreign Ministry said earlier this week would be upcoming "systemic strikes" on Kyiv.

The Ukrainian Foreign Ministry said Thursday that all diplomatic missions in the capital have continued operations.

AGENCIES

'Treasury officials moot \$250 note featuring Trump'

WASHINGTON: The US may have a USD 250 currency note featuring a portrait of President Donald Trump if administration officials succeed in getting a Congressional nod for the move, according to a media report on Thursday.

The development comes little over two months after it was announced that Trump will feature on a gold coin to commemorate the nation's 250th anniversary.

On Thursday, the Washington Post reported that US Treasurer Brandon Beach and his senior adviser Mike Brown urged the staff at the Treasury Department's Bureau of Engraving and Printing (BEP) to pre-

pare prototypes of the USD 250 note.

According to the US federal law, only deceased persons can be featured on currency notes. The US Congress will have to pass a new law to allow Trump's portrait to feature on a currency note.

As part of the effort, Beach provided bureau staff with mock-up designs for the note in August and September. One design showed Trump's face in the centre of the USD 250 note between the signatures of the president and Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent, The Post reported, quoting Treasury Department employees.

The artist who designed the

mock-up told The Post that he had spoken with Trump about it.

British painter Iain Alexander said Trump endorsed changes to his original design, such as adding the colours of the American flag and a logo commemorating the 250th anniversary of the nation's founding.

No living person has appeared on US currency since 1866, when it was outlawed after the image of a mid-level Treasury bureaucrat featured on a five-cent note.

A draft law allowing Trump to appear on a USD 250 note was introduced in Congress last year to commemorate the nation's 250th anniversary.

In a statement to The Post, a Treasury Department spokesperson said the printing office "is conducting appropriate planning and due diligence" in response to the proposed legislation.

"Should this legislative mandate be signed into law, the BEP is moving proactively to produce a USD 250 commemorative note which will appropriately recognise the 250th Anniversary of our great nation," the statement said.

The effort to print a USD 250 note coincides with the Trump administration's plans to celebrate the 250th anniversary of America's founding starting this July.

AGENCIES

World Briefs

INDIA TO BUILD 14 SCHOOLS IN NEPAL'S EARTHQUAKE-HIT DISTRICTS

KATHMANDU: India has pledged Nepali Rupees 560.2 million for the construction of 14 schools in eight earthquake-affected districts of Nepal, reaffirming its commitment to the Himalayan nation's post-disaster reconstruction and socio-economic development. The Central Level Project Implementation Unit-Education under Nepal's Ministry of Education and Sports has signed agreements for the construction of 14 schools across eight districts of Nepal under a Government of India grant of Nepali Rupees 560.2 million, the Indian Embassy in Kathmandu said in a press statement on Wednesday.

BRAZIL TO ADOPT 40-HR, 5-DAY WORKWEEK

SAO PAULO: Brazil was set to join other Latin American countries that have shortened working hours as the lower house approved a constitutional amendment Wednesday establishing a 40-hour, five-day workweek. The proposal is widely popular in Brazil ahead of presidential elections in October, and President Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva sponsored the move and has repeatedly promoted it. The amendment is also part of a push within the region has been lauded by labour rights groups but highly criticised by the business sector. It guarantees two consecutive 24-hour rest days each week, preferably Saturdays and Sundays.

France to repeal Code Noir, slavery law it never abolished

PARIS: French lawmakers are expected to vote on a bill to formally repeal Code Noir, a 1685 decree that regulated slavery in France's colonies and classified enslaved people as property, nearly 180 years after slavery was abolished in the country.

The legislation, expected to be examined by the National Assembly on Thursday, would remove the colonial-era text from French law. Although Code Noir lost legal authority when France abolished slavery in 1848, it was never formally repealed.

The decree, signed by King Louis XIV, governed slavery across French colonies in the Caribbean and elsewhere. Article 44 declared enslaved people to be "movable property." Other provisions allowed harsh punishments for those who escaped and denied legal standing to enslaved people in court.

President Emmanuel Macron said last week that the law's continued presence in the legal code should not have lasted so long after the abolition of slavery.

"The silence, even the indifference, that we have maintained

for nearly two centuries toward this Black Code is no longer an oversight," Macron said. "It has become a form of offense."

France was one of the major participants in the trans-Atlantic slave trade, transporting around 1.4 million Africans to plantations in its colonies. Wealth generated through slavery contributed to the growth of cities such as Nantes and Bordeaux.

The proposal to repeal the law was introduced by Max Mathiasin, a lawmaker from Guadeloupe. He said he had owned copies of the text for years but had never fully read it.

"As the great-great-grandson of people who were enslaved, I had never been able to read it in full," he said. "This was made by human beings against human beings."

Mathiasin described the repeal effort as a way to recognize the dignity of descendants of enslaved people and to bring France closer to its republican ideals of liberty, equality and fraternity.

France retained several former slave colonies after aboli-

France May Repeal Code Noir

Colonial-era slavery decree remained in French law despite abolition in 1848



French lawmakers are expected to vote on a bill to formally repeal Code Noir, the 1685 decree that regulated slavery in France's colonies and classified enslaved people as property.

The law lost legal force when France abolished slavery in 1848, but it has never been formally repealed.

Today's reality

Overseas departments have higher unemployment rates than metropolitan France.

In Mayotte, more than three-quarters of households live below the national poverty line.

Compensation for enslaved people is not paid.

France has not fully acknowledged its role in the transatlantic slave trade.

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- » Declared 'movable property'
- » Allowed harsh punishments for fugitives and other crimes
- » Denied any legal standing: the testimony of an enslaved person counted for nothing
- » France compensated about 1.4 million Africans in the transatlantic slave trade, but has never fully acknowledged its role in the transatlantic slave trade

tion. Guadeloupe, Martinique, French Guiana and Réunion became overseas departments in 1946, giving them the same legal status as regions in mainland France. Their combined population of around 1.9 million people are French citizens, many descended from enslaved Africans.

Despite that status, the territories continue to face high levels of poverty and unemployment. Unemployment rates are roughly double those of mainland France in some overseas departments. In Mayotte, more than three-quarters of households live below the national poverty line.

EARNINGS REFLECT A RETURN TO NORMAL PROFITABILITY

OMCs post combined net profit of ₹77,821 cr in FY26

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: State-run oil marketing companies (OMCs) posted a combined net profit of Rs 77,821 crore in FY26, but the earnings reflect a return to normal profitability rather than a crisis-driven windfall, according to government and industry data reviewed amid criticism over fuel price hikes following the West Asia conflict.

The profit pool, spread across Indian Oil Corporation (IOC), Bharat Petroleum Corporation Ltd (BPCL) and Hindustan Petroleum Corporation Ltd (HPCL), amounts to a net margin of roughly 3-4 per cent on combined turnover estimated near Rs 20 lakh crore, broadly in line with global commodity refining benchmarks.

Criticism from opposition parties has centred on the 130 per cent jump in profits from FY25 levels. However, FY25 profits had fallen sharply to Rs 33,602 crore after OMCs absorbed Rs 40,434 crore in LPG under-recoveries to keep household cylinder prices capped, creating what officials describe as an artificially depressed comparison base.

Adjusted for that one-off burden, FY26 profitability is broadly comparable with FY24 combined profits of Rs 80,986 crore, rather than an exceptional spike.



Profit pool, spread across IOC, BPCL & HPCL, amounts to a net margin of roughly 3-4% on combined turnover estimated near Rs 20 lakh crore

Industry officials argue the scale of earnings must be viewed against the size of operations. India's three OMCs together generate annual revenue of about Rs 20 lakh crore, while individual refiners such as IOC alone post turnover close to Rs 10 lakh crore annually. Analysts say a 1-3 per cent operating margin is typical for large commodity refiners and necessary to sustain capital expenditure, refinery upgrades and working capital requirements.

A single refinery expansion programme can cost between Rs 50,000 crore and Rs 60,000 crore, with the sector target-

Highlights

- » Criticism from opposition parties has centred on the 130 per cent jump in profits from FY25 levels
- » FY25 profits had fallen sharply to Rs 33,602 cr after OMCs absorbed Rs 40,434 cr in LPG under-recoveries to keep household cylinder prices capped
- » FY2025-26 profitability is broadly comparable with FY2023-24 combined profits of Rs 80,986 crore

ing refining capacity expansion beyond 310 million tonnes per annum by 2030.

The companies also contend that FY2025-26 earnings were largely insulated from the impact of the Strait of Hormuz disruption because refiners were processing 50-60 days of pre-conflict crude inventory purchased before the escalation in West Asia.

As a result, the higher crude acquisition costs, freight premiums and insurance surcharges linked to the conflict are expected to be reflected mainly in Q1 FY27 earnings, due for publication in August.

The Strait of Hormuz carries nearly one-fifth of global crude flows and its disruption triggered a sharp rise in oil prices and shipping costs across Asia.

The government has defended recent retail fuel price increases - about Rs 7.50 per litre in petrol and diesel and Rs 6 per kg in CNG, saying India's pump price revisions remain moderate compared with neighbouring economies despite the supply shock.

Since the crisis began in late February, retail petrol and diesel prices in India have risen by about 8-9 per cent, according to official estimates, compared with increases ranging from 20 per cent to 67 per cent in several neighbouring countries.

New Delhi also cut excise duty on petrol and diesel by Rs 10 per litre effective March 27, 2026, adding to earlier excise reductions announced in 2021 and 2022. Officials said cumulative excise relief since 2021 totals Rs 23 per litre on petrol and Rs 26 per litre on diesel.

The government further argued that roughly half of OMC profits flow back to the exchequer through dividends and taxes, helping fund infrastructure spending including highways, railways and metro projects, while retained earnings support energy security investments and refining expansion.

ONGC yet to take control of Cambay Block as Vedanta challenges govt move

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: State-owned Oil and Natural Gas Corporation (ONGC) has yet to take operational control of the Cambay basin block CB-OS-02 in Gujarat after Vedanta challenged the government's decision not to extend the block's contract term.

The Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, through a September 19, 2025, directive, rejected an extension of the contract for the block, in which ONGC holds a 50 per cent participating interest, Vedanta holds 40 per cent, and Invenire Petrodyne Limited holds 10 per cent.

Following the government's decision, ONGC said it was instructed to immediately take over operations of the block and deployed an operational team to Suvali in Gujarat from September 20, 2025.

However, the company said Vedanta has not yet handed over operations.

"Pursuant to the Government of India directive, ONGC requested Vedanta for the immediate handover and deployed its operational team at Suvali, Gujarat, from September 20, 2025. However, Vedanta has not yet handed over the operations," ONGC said in notes to its FY26 earnings statement.

According to ONGC, Vedanta filed a writ petition before the Delhi High Court on September 22, 2025, challenging the said rejection of the extension of the terms of



According to ONGC, Vedanta filed a writ petition before the Delhi High Court on September 22, 2025, challenging the said rejection of the extension of the terms of the contract.

"The court asked the respondents to file their response/counter affidavit and directed them to maintain the status quo in the matter. Further, all the hearings have been completed on May 18, 2026, and the matter has been reserved for order by the court," it said.

"Pending the outcome of the proceedings, Vedanta continues to act as the operator for the block," ONGC said. "The company remains in preparedness to assume operational control of the block as and when directed by the Government of India."

"The courts have ordered the parties to maintain sta-

tus quo. We cannot comment beyond this as the matter is sub-judice," a Vedanta Cairn spokesperson said.

Vedanta Cairn Oil and Gas, a unit of Mumbai-listed Vedanta Ltd, was the operator of the Gujarat offshore block CB-OS/2 with a 40 per cent stake. The Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas has, in a September 19, 2025, letter, informed the partners that the application to extend the production sharing contract (PSC) for CB-OS/2 has not been accepted.

While no reasons were stated for the move, ONGC was asked to take over the operations in the interim period.

PSC is an agreement between the government and a resource extraction company. It gives the company time-specified right to explore, develop and produce resources in exchange for a pre-agreed share of the produced output (known as profit petroleum) once costs are recovered.

The CB-OS/2 block, which holds Lakshmi and Gauri fields and produces about 3,400 barrels of oil per day and 3.4 lakh standard cubic metres of gas per day, was one of the three properties operated by Cairn India when billionaire Anil Agarwal's group acquired the firm in 2011 for \$8.67 billion.

The other assets of Cairn India were the Barmer oil fields in Rajasthan and the Ravva oil and gas fields in the Krishna Godavari basin off the Andhra coast.

Cairn India was merged into Vedanta Ltd in 2017.

Vedanta Cairn Oil & Gas spokesperson had in September last year stated that the block contributed less than 0.3 per cent to the overall EBITDA of Vedanta.

The PSC for CB-OS/2 block was signed on August 30, 1998, and the contract expired on June 30, 2023.

The Vedanta-led consortium continued to operate the block during the pendency of its application for extension of the PSC.

After the PSC extension was rejected, the block had to return to the government.

Prior to the denial of extension for CB-OS/2, the government had extended the contracts for Vedanta Cairn's two other blocks - a 10-year PSC extension was approved for the Rajasthan block RJ-ON-90/1 till May 14, 2030, and a similar period was given for the PKGM-1 block, more commonly known as the Ravva field, till October 27, 2029.

According to a DeGolyer and MacNaughton reserve report commissioned by Vedanta Cairn in 2019, CB-OS/2 block's two discoveries, Gauri and Lakshmi, held a total in-place reserves of 13.6 million barrels of oil and oil equivalent gas.

While the block PSC expired, Vedanta Cairn had pressed ahead with its development plan for the discoveries in the 3,314 square kilometre shallow water block.

Ambani draws no salary for 6th year in row



NEW DELHI: Mukesh Ambani drew no salary from Reliance Industries (RIL) for sixth straight year in FY26, with dividends remaining his primary source of income, according to the company's annual report.

Ambani, who had capped his annual remuneration at Rs 15 crore between 2008-09 and 2019-20, voluntarily gave up his salary in June 2020 during the Covid-19 pandemic and has continued to forgo salary, allowances, perquisites and stock options since then.

RIL reported a record consolidated net profit of Rs 95,754 crore in FY26 and a mcap of Rs 18.19 lakh crore. Ambani directly owns 1.61 crore Reliance shares and earned about Rs 9.66 crore as dividend income based on the Rs 6 per share dividend declared for FY25.

Promoter group entities controlled by him hold 50.07 per cent stake, translating into dividend income of nearly Rs 3,987 crore. His children — Isha Ambani, Akash Ambani and Anant Ambani — received sitting fees and commissions, while executive director Anant drew a salary of Rs 12.17 crore in FY26.

AGENCIES

Vaping a 'new gateway' to addiction, will raise issue in Parliament, says Swati Maliwal

NEW DELHI: Swati Maliwal on Thursday called vaping a "new gateway" to addiction and said she would raise the issue in Parliament, warning that e-cigarettes are increasingly being used by children as young as 12 despite a nationwide ban.

Speaking at a seminar organised by Mothers Against Vaping ahead of World No Tobacco Day 2026, Maliwal said vaping has become normalised among young people because of the "complete absence of stigma".

She said India took a decisive step through the Prohibition of Electronic Cigarettes Act, 2019, but vaping devices continue to be sold in grey markets, especially in metropolitan cities. "The age of first experimentation is dropping," she said.



Maliwal described vapes as devices that heat chemical liquids containing nicotine, formaldehyde, diacetyl and heavy metals into aerosols inhaled directly into the lungs.

She warned of risks including adolescent brain development issues, lung injuries, cardiovascular complications, carcinogen exposure and mental health dependency. The seminar, titled "Unmasking the

Vaping has become normalised among young people because of 'complete absence of stigma, she said

Appeal: Protecting Children from New-Age Gateway Products", brought together experts from health, science, education and law enforcement to discuss vaping devices, nicotine pouches and synthetic nicotine products.

Maliwal also criticised the marketing of vaping products through flavours, sleek designs and social media influencers. She said products disguised as

pens or USB drives make them easier to conceal from parents and teachers. Shalini Singh of the Indian Council of Medical Research's National Institute of Cancer Prevention and Research questioned claims that vaping is a safer alternative to smoking, saying independent scientific reviews supported the ban on such products.

Dr Raj Kumar of the University of Delhi said vaping is often wrongly perceived as harmless by young people experimenting due to curiosity or peer pressure. Participants called for stricter enforcement against illicit sales, stronger accountability from digital platforms and inclusion of anti-vaping awareness in NCERT curricula.

AGENCIES

RIL secures Japan financing after S&P upgrade to A-

NEW DELHI: Reliance Industries Ltd (RIL) executed the largest-ever Samurai loan raised by an Indian corporate in FY26 and completed three first-of-their-kind global financing deals after a credit rating upgrade by S&P Global Ratings.

S&P upgraded Reliance's international debt rating to A- from BBB+ in December 2025, placing it two notches above India's sovereign rating. The company said the upgrade would improve access to overseas capital and lower borrowing costs.

According to its annual report, Reliance raised JPY 91.9 billion (about \$625 million) through a Samurai loan involving 10 Japanese and Tai-

wanese banks, marking the largest such financing by an Indian corporate.

The company also secured about \$500 million equivalent in financing backed by Korea's export credit agency KSURE and another \$600 million equivalent facility backed by Japan's NEXI for its solar photovoltaic and battery gigafactory projects.

Reliance said the deals highlighted its ability to raise multi-currency funding at competitive rates despite volatile global markets and rupee depreciation.

As of March 31, 2026, Reliance reported gross debt of Rs 3.74 lakh crore and net debt of Rs 1.25 lakh crore.

AGENCIES

RIL commissions 1st solar modules from Jamnagar green energy complex

NEW DELHI: Reliance Industries Limited has delivered the first 200 megawatt-peak batch of high-efficiency solar modules from its green energy manufacturing complex in Jamnagar, Gujarat, marking the operational rollout of its New Energy business in FY26.

According to the company's annual report, the first batch of 720-watt-peak BIS-certified heterojunction technology (HJT) solar panels offers around 10 per cent higher energy yield and 25 per cent lower degradation than prevailing industry benchmarks.

Reliance said it is progressively commissioning cell and module manufacturing lines and remains on track to scale



solar manufacturing capacity to 10 GW annually, with plans to expand to 20 GW.

The company's battery energy storage system (BESS) giga-factory has also entered advanced commissioning, targeting an initial annual capacity of 40 GWh.

Production at the lithium iron phosphate battery facility is expected to ramp up in the second half of 2026.

Production at lithium iron phosphate battery facility is expected to ramp up in H2 of 2026

Reliance has also begun work on its electrolyser giga-factory after securing technology licensing rights from Norway-based Nel ASA for alkaline electrolysers.

The company aims to build 3 million metric tonnes of green hydrogen capacity annually by 2032 and has committed around Rs 75,000 crore toward its clean energy platform.

AGENCIES

REC LIMITED MOU SIGNING



REC Limited signed an MoU with the Electrical Research and Development Association (ERDA) on Wednesday at SCOPE Complex, New Delhi, to strengthen quality testing & assurance mechanisms for materials deployed under Revamped Distribution Sector Scheme (RDSS). The MoU was signed by Prabhat Kumar Singh, Executive Director (RDSS), REC Ltd and Brijesh Sachdeva, Head, ERDA North, in the presence of Prince Dhawan, IAS, Executive Director (PMD), REC Ltd and senior officials from both organisations.

MPOST

Global growth to weaken, India stands out with strongest growth prospect: WEF survey

Chief economists ranked the current closure duration of the Strait of Hormuz as significantly more disruptive than last year's tariff turmoil

NEW DELHI: Chief economists across the world expect the global economic growth to weaken over the next one year, but India stands out as a geography with the strongest growth expectations, a new WEF survey showed on Thursday.

In its latest Chief Economists' Outlook, the World Economic Forum (WEF) said nearly nine in ten chief economists surveyed expect global growth to weaken over the coming year, though only 13 per cent think there could be a global recession.

According to the survey, 94 per cent expected global inflation to rise due to the closure of

the Strait of Hormuz driving up energy and food costs and disrupting supply chains.

The survey showed a reversal of the cautious optimism seen at the start of the year, as conflict in the Middle East and the closure of the Strait of Hormuz fuel concerns over a major global economic shock.

Chief economists ranked the current closure duration of the Strait of Hormuz as significantly more disruptive than last year's tariff turmoil.

If the closure persists in the second half of the year, they expect its impact could approach the severity of the COVID-19 crisis, compounding effects across global supply



chains, energy and food costs.

"Only months ago, the Chief Economists community was cautiously optimistic. The conflict in the Middle East changed that, and the economic scarring from the situation thus far is already expected to last into the months ahead,"

CLOSER LOOK

- » If Hormuz closure persists in H2 of year, its impact could approach severity of COVID-19 crisis, compounding effects across global supply chains, energy & food costs
- » 'The longer the disruption lasts, the heavier the long-term cost for those who can least afford it'
- » The survey said the crisis is expected to hit the Middle East and North Africa region the hardest

WEF Managing Director Saadia Zahidi said.

"The longer the disruption lasts, the heavier the long-term cost for those who can least afford it," she added.

The survey said the crisis is expected to hit the Middle East and North Africa region

the hardest.

By contrast, India and the United States are expected to remain relatively resilient, supported by domestic demand and investment, the World Economic Forum said.

Specifically about India, it said the country's growth pros-

pects continue to stand out.

"Of the chief economists surveyed, 52 per cent expect strong or very strong growth in the year ahead, making India the geography with the strongest growth expectations in the survey," it said.

Early 2026 reporting pointed to a broader opening in trade policy and to a policy push behind infrastructure, technology and domestic capacity-building, according to the WEF.

While the economy still remains resilient and growth for 2026-27 is projected at 6.5 per cent, it still faces rising risks from the conflict in the Middle East.

"Depreciation pressures have forced the central bank to shed \$40 billion in foreign-exchange reserves in March to stabilise the currency," it added.

On the global business environment, the WEF said, India offers the clearest blend of scale, growth and potential among large emerging markets.

It noted that the country has kept opening channels for trade and capital, maintaining an active economic policy stance and expanding market access.

In particular, India embraced free trade by entering into new agreements, including with the EU, it said.

On the impact of the West Asia crisis, the WEF said the main pressure point is energy prices.

In most regions, energy prices are expected to increase and energy price increases were repeatedly flagged by the vast majority of surveyed chief economists among the major concerns in the current global outlook.

Southeast Asia is expected to bear the brunt, with 62 per cent of respondents anticipating significantly higher energy prices over the next 12 months.

However, this number dropped to 45 per cent in Europe and to 41 per cent in both Japan and India.

PTI

India & Canada to avoid sensitive sectors in FTA talks: Piyush Goyal

Both countries are negotiating a Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement. The third round of negotiations is underway in Ottawa

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India and Canada have decided to focus on low-hanging fruit, work on areas of convergence and avoid seeking concessions in sensitive sectors in the negotiations for the proposed free trade agreement (FTA), Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal has said.

The two countries are negotiating a Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA). The third round of negotiations is underway in Ottawa. The minister was in Canada for a three-day official visit.

"I remember when I was talking to Mr Maninder Sidhu (Canada's trade minister) about speeding up CEPA negotiations, one of the first elementary decisions we both took was that 'we won't make perfect the enemy of the good'."

"Let's capture the low-hanging fruit. Let's look at areas of convergence. Let's leave the sensitive things out of the agreement. If something is sensitive for Canada, no sense in trying to egg on and trying to get that into the CEPA. Likewise, if something is sensitive for India or the Indian public or Indian businesses, no sense that we



Union Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal meets Ontario Teachers' Pension Plan President and CEO Jo Taylor during his three-day official visit to Canada

'Let's capture the low-hanging fruit. Let's look at areas of convergence. Let's leave the sensitive things out of the agreement,' Piyush Goyal said

break our heads trying to navigate that path," he said while addressing the Ontario Centre of Innovation on May 27.

Under such pacts, India does not grant market access in areas such as agri-commodities and dairy.

Both sides are looking at

concluding the negotiations for the proposed pact by year-end. The two countries have also set a target to increase bilateral trade from the current \$17 billion to \$50 billion by 2030.

In such pacts, two trading partners significantly reduce and eliminate import duties on

Highlights

» 'If something is sensitive for Canada, no sense in trying to egg on and trying to get that into the CEPA'

» 'Likewise, if something is sensitive for India or the Indian public or Indian businesses, no sense that we break our heads trying to navigate that path,' Goyal said

» Under such pacts, India does not grant market access in areas such as agri-commodities and dairy

» The two countries have also set a target to increase bilateral trade from current \$17 billion to \$50 billion by 2030

the maximum number of goods traded between them. Besides, they also ease norms to promote trade in services and boost investments.

Goyal also said that during his visit, he met government representatives, businesses, investment companies, pen-

sion funds, and insurance companies.

Seeking investment from Canadian firms, he said India is known for protecting intellectual property.

India, he said, has the third-largest startup ecosystem, with about 2.3 lakh entities registered as startups.

"The digital public infrastructure is another area where India has demonstrated tremendous capabilities to the world, as well as offered itself and these technologies for wider public good across the world," Goyal said, adding that vast potential for bilateral cooperation is there in sectors such as AI, cleantech, agritech, and deep tech.

During his meeting with Jo Taylor, President and CEO of Ontario Teachers' Pension Plan, he discussed investment opportunities in India across infrastructure, renewables, financial services, healthcare, technology, and the digital economy.

Goyal also met John Graham, President and CEO of CPP Investments, and discussed expanding long-term institutional investments in India across infrastructure, logistics, renewable energy, transportation, financial services, and digital infrastructure.

CEPA review talks: India, Korea agree to address trade deficit

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India and South Korea have agreed to address the widening trade deficit between the two countries within the overall framework of the bilateral trade pact, the Commerce Ministry said on Thursday.

The two nations also decided to constitute sub-groups to discuss cooperation in the areas of digital trade, supply chain and strategic industrial collaboration.

The issue figured during the 12th round meeting on the up-gradation of the existing comprehensive economic partnership agreement (CEPA), which was implemented in January 2010.

"Both sides acknowledged India's bilateral trade deficit, which has risen significantly since the IK CEPA came into force in 2010, and agreed to address the issue within the overall IK (India-Korea) CEPA framework," the ministry said.

India's exports to Korea increased 3.31 per cent to \$6 billion in 2025-26 from \$5.81 billion in 2024-25. The export growth was negative during 2022-25.

Imports grew 1.38 per cent to \$21.35 billion in 2025-26 from \$21 billion in 2024-25.

The trade deficit widened to \$15.35 billion in 2025-26, from \$15.2 billion in 2024-25. The deficit stood at \$14.71 billion in 2023-24, up from \$14.57 billion in 2022-23 and \$9.4 billion in 2021-22.

The ministry said that



India's exports to Korea increased 3.31 per cent to \$6 billion in 2025-26 from \$5.81 billion in 2024-25. The export growth was negative during 2022-25

both sides reviewed the progress achieved so far in the negotiations.

During the current round, discussions were held on trade in goods, trade in services, rules of origin and origin procedures, investment, and sanitary and phytosanitary (SPS) standards.

The negotiations were co-chaired by Kapil Chaudhary, Joint Secretary, Department of Commerce, and Park Geunoh, Director General for Trade Agreement Policy, Ministry of Trade, Industry and Energy,

Republic of Korea.

According to experts, Indian exporters face certain non-tariff barriers in South Korea, including stringent standards, regulations and certification requirements, which make it difficult for Indian goods to penetrate the Korean market.

The two countries aim to double their two-way commerce to \$54 billion by 2030 from the current \$27 billion, while ensuring a more balanced trade relationship.

In a CEPA, two or more countries either significantly reduce or eliminate customs duties on the maximum number of goods added between and ease norms to promote trade in services and boost investments.

Generally, review or upgradation exercises of a trade agreement include implementation issues, rules of origin, verification process and release of consignments, customs procedures, further liberalisation of trade in goods, and sharing and exchange of trade data.

NFL records net profit of ₹169.65 cr in FY 2025-26



NOIDA: National Fertilizers Limited, a Government of India Navratna undertaking, has recorded strong financial year 2025-26 results with standalone net profit of Rs 169.65 crore, more than double of Rs 76.26 crore, recorded in the previous year.

The profit before tax increased to Rs 232.67 crore from the Rs 104.08 crore recorded in FY 2024-25.

The standalone revenue from operations increased to Rs 21,514.18 crore from Rs 19,794.50 crore in FY 2024-25 reflecting significantly improved operational efficiency and higher revenue.

The total sale of the fertilizers this year stood at 65.20 Lakh MT compared to 63.78 LMT recorded in FY 2024-25.

For the quarter ended March 31, 2026, the company reported standalone revenue from operations of Rs 4,347.19 crore and a net profit of Rs 118.19 crore.

The company has showed a strong improvement in its annual financial performance for financial year 2025-26.

The Board of Directors approved the audited results at its meeting held on May 27, 2026.

NHAI identifies 17 highway assets for monetisation during fiscal 2026-27

NEW DELHI: State-owned NHAI on Thursday said it has identified 17 National Highways assets with a total combined length of 1,692.5 km for monetisation under the toll-operate-transfer (TOT) and infrastructure investment trust (InvIT) modes during the financial year 2026-27.

NHAI, in a statement, said the identified National Highways assets comprise stretches across nine states, including Haryana, Jharkhand, Karnataka, Rajasthan, Tamil Nadu, Telangana, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, and Maharashtra.

These Highway assets collectively represent economic and logistics corridors with established traffic potential and robust connectivity significance, it added. NHAI said the monetization exercise will be undertaken through transparent and



However, the list does not include the assets proposed to be monetised through Raajmarg Infra Investment Trust (RIIT) for FY27

structured mechanisms under the TOT and InvIT frameworks. TOT and InvIT have emerged as successful models

for attracting long-term institutional investment into further expanding the National Highway infrastructure by adopting innovative financing mechanisms for sustainable infrastructure development while ensuring efficient asset management and operational excellence.

However, the list does not include the assets proposed to be monetised through Raajmarg Infra Investment Trust (RIIT) for FY27, it added.

The 17 identified National Highways assets include — Hazaribagh-Barhi-Koderma section of NH-20 (68.8 km), Delhi/Haryana Border to Rohtak of NH-9 from KM 29.7 to KM 87 in the State of Haryana (52 km), Trichy to Thuvranakurichi Madurai of NH-38 (124.8 km) and Aligarh to Kanpur section of NH-34 (283.8 km).

PTI

IMEC, Indo-Pacific routes could significantly reduce reliance on Strait of Hormuz, says EY

'India must prepare for future shocks by building strategic reserves of crude oil, LPG, fertilisers, rare earth materials, medicines & medical equipment'

NEW DELHI: India should diversify its trade routes and speed up development of alternative connectivity corridors such as the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor (IMEC) and the Indo-Pacific route via the Malacca Strait to reduce dependence on the Strait of Hormuz, according to an EY report.

The EY Economy Watch report for May said the ongoing West Asia crisis and the changing global trade order may require India to recast its growth strategy to safeguard its medium- and long-term economic trajectory.

EY said India must prepare



for future economic shocks by building strategic reserves of crude oil, LPG, fertilisers, rare earth materials, medicines and medical equipment.

It also recommended developing dual-use infrastructure to tackle possible nuclear and

It also stressed on the need to accelerate domestic oil exploration and expand reserves of key imported commodities

biological threats while maintaining sustainable fiscal and current account balances.

The report called for faster adoption of green and nuclear energy, including Thorium-based production, along with a stronger push towards elec-

tric vehicles and indigenous technologies.

It also stressed the need to accelerate domestic oil exploration and expand reserves of key imported commodities.

Oil prices have risen about 50 per cent since Iran blocked the Strait of Hormuz following coordinated US-Israel strikes on February 28, while shipping traffic through the route has reportedly fallen over 90 per cent from pre-conflict levels.

India imports nearly 88 per cent of its crude oil and about half of its natural gas needs, much of it through the Strait of Hormuz.

AGENCIES

OGEL & HWT ink JV for bioenergy, waste projects

NEW DELHI: OIL Green Energy Ltd. (OGEL), a wholly owned subsidiary of Oil India Limited (OIL) and Hindustan Waste Treatment Pvt. Ltd. (HWT), a wholly owned subsidiary of SFC Environmental Technologies Ltd, have signed a Joint Venture Agreement (JVA) to collaborate in the development of integrated bioenergy and sustainable waste management projects in India.

The partnership envisages formation of a 50:50 joint venture company to pursue opportunities in compressed biogas (CBG), waste-to-energy and allied sustainable infrastructure projects aligned with India's clean energy transition and circular economy objectives.

OIL is a Maharatna Central Public Sector Enterprise under the Ministry of Petroleum & Natural Gas and one of India's leading integrated energy companies. With a strong presence across the hydrocarbon value chain encompassing exploration, production and transportation of crude oil and natural gas, OIL is also steadily advancing its presence in renewable and green energy domains in alignment with India's evolving energy transition agenda.

The proposed joint venture will explore opportunities in CBG, integrated waste-to-energy and sustainable resource recovery projects across suitable geographies in India.

MPOST

BoB adds biometric, IoT features, face authentication to bob e-Pay

MUMBAI: Bank of Baroda on Wednesday introduced three new features on its UPI app, bob e-Pay, including biometric authentication, Aadhaar-based face authentication for UPI PIN management, and Internet of Things (IoT)-based payments.

The bank said bob e-Pay, a universal UPI application open to customers of all banks, will now allow users to authorise UPI payments of up to Rs 5,000 using fingerprint or face ID registered on their mobile devices.

The feature supports both person-to-person and merchant transactions and eliminates the need for PIN entry



for smaller payments.

Bank of Baroda has also enabled UIDAI-based face authentication for setting or resetting UPI PINs. The feature reduces dependence on debit cards and Aadhaar OTP verification by allowing customers to verify identity through facial recognition along with a

bank OTP.

In addition, the lender has introduced IoT-based UPI payments, enabling customers to make transactions through connected vehicles and smart appliances linked to bob e-Pay.

The bank said the IoT payment feature works under the delegate payments framework, allowing a primary user to authorise a secondary user or connected device to carry out transactions within preset limits.

Sanjay Mudaliar, Executive Director, Bank of Baroda, said the new features are aimed at making digital payments more seamless, secure and user-friendly.

MPOST

Pushp Kumar Nayar takes Charge as Director (HR), Bharat Petroleum

NEW DELHI: Pushp Kumar Nayar on Thursday assumed charge as Director (Human Resources) at Bharat Petroleum Corporation Limited.

Nayar brings more than 35 years of experience across retail, lubricants and human resources functions. Prior to this role, he served as Executive Director (HRD) at BPCL, where he led initiatives in talent development, succession planning, leadership development and HR analytics-driven decision-making. During his career, he has held several leadership roles across business verticals and geographies, including a deputation stint at Indraprastha Gas Limited. He has also served on the boards of Central UP Gas Limited and Sabarmati Gas Limited, and currently chairs Arunachal Gas Private Limited.



MPOST

SEIL Energy hosts thermal power automation meet

Over 150 delegates from over 30 power companies & equipment suppliers attended the event

NEW DELHI: SEIL Energy India Ltd hosted South India's first dedicated conference on control, instrumentation and automation in thermal power plants at Nellore, Andhra Pradesh.

The two-day event, C&I Connect 2026, brought together more than 150 delegates from over 30 power companies and equipment suppliers across Andhra Pradesh, Telangana, Tamil Nadu and Karnataka.

The conference focused on sustainable solutions through advanced instrumentation and cyber-resilient systems in thermal power plants. Discussions



Left to right: Sunil Kumar Gupta, Head – O&M, SEIL Energy India Ltd, K Srinivasa Rao, Director (Technical & Projects) – APPDCL (Chief guest), Janmejaya Mahapatra, CEO – SEIL Energy India Ltd and B Madhava Rao, Head – C&I Department, SEIL Energy India Ltd.

covered digital control systems,

Industrial IoT and OT cyberse-

CLOSER LOOK

» The conference focused on sustainable solutions through advanced instrumentation and cyber-resilient systems in thermal power plants

» 'Thermal power will continue to remain central to India's energy security,' Janmejaya Mahapatra, CEO of SEIL Energy India, said

curity, AI/ML-based predictive

maintenance, automatic generation control, flexible plant operations and environmental compliance.

Chief guest K Srinivasa Rao, Director (Thermal & Projects), APPDCL, said such platforms are essential as power plants face growing operational efficiency and digital resilience challenges.

Janmejaya Mahapatra, CEO of SEIL Energy India, said thermal power will continue to remain central to India's energy security, while stressing the importance of intelligent systems, cyber security and innovation in plant operations.

MPOST

MUMBAI: National Stock Exchange (NSE) of India announced a collaboration with Sequel Logistics for the creation and vaulting of Electronic Gold Receipts (EGRs), marking the launch with a ceremonial bell-ringing event.

The partnership was formally marked on Wednesday with a ceremonial bell-ringing to commemorate the commencement of EGR trading on NSE and the joint commitment of both institutions to build a robust EGR ecosystem in India.

Sequel Logistics currently operates a network of 23 vaults across the country, at which



investors and market participants will be able to create and extinguish EGRs.

The vaulting network forms a critical part of the EGR value

chain, ensuring secure storage of the underlying physical gold backing every Electronic Gold Receipt issued on the Exchange.

MPOST



KUMUD MISHRA ON SOCIAL MEDIA RACE

‘I NEVER FELT THE NEED’

The versatile actor plays the antagonist in ‘Satrangi: Badle Ka Khel’

ANINDITA ACHARYA

Like many, actor Kumud Mishra believes that his role as Dhingra, a mentor to Ranbir Kapoor’s Jordan in Imtiaz Ali’s ‘Rockstar’ changed the game for him in Bollywood. But then, Mishra is such a versatile actor that it’s difficult to pick one role that isn’t great. And we are not talking about length here. Be it the supportive father in ‘Thappad’, carefree blind man in ‘Nazar Andaz’, a government officer in ‘Airlift’ or the twinkly-eyed lawyer in ‘The Diplomat’, here’s an actor who fits easily into any role.

“After ‘Rockstar’, people noticed me. ‘Airlift’ was also an important film. I highly rate the performance in the film. Also, I keep getting praises for ‘Thappad’ too,” he smiled over the phone as the correspondent complimented him on his versatility.

An alumnus of the National School of Drama, Delhi, Mishra was content with his life in theatre.

In 1996, he acted in Shyam Benegal’s ‘Sardari Begum’. A good-looking actor, in an interview, Manoj Bajpayee once said Mahesh Bhatt wanted to cast him as a hero, but Mishra denied it. An underrated gem in Hindi cinema now, Mishra’s journey on the big screen took off with ‘Rockstar’ in 2011. “So, you never wanted to be a hero?” we ask him. In his effortless style, he laughed it off.

“No, if it was meant to happen, it would have happened. Now, we can think about it and be cynical. But then, I lived my life my way. The way I have lived my life, I think, I have done something right,” smiled the ‘Article 15’ and ‘Lust Stories 2’ actor.

In 2026, he already had four releases, including ‘Vadh 2’, ‘Assi’, ‘Hathras’ and now ‘Satrangi: Badle Ka Khel’ on ‘Zee5’. In ‘Satrangi’, he plays antagonist Sona Singh, the powerful patriarch of the Singh family. ‘Satrangi’, like several web shows, are set in the Hindi heartland where power politics, rural tension, caste and humiliation rule supreme. For Mishra, it’s always the script that pushes him to choose a project. In ‘Satrangi’, the actor felt that the story was layered.

“The show deals with topics which should be discussed,” he said.

It doesn’t matter whether he plays an antagonist or a good-hearted man, Mishra always manages to stand out for his performance.

“Whenever I play a negative character, I don’t look at it pessimistically. I look for



I think you do theatre, because you need it. I am talking about myself. Theatre is a completely different space for me”

positivity in the character. A person who is doing something wrong doesn’t do it thinking that he is an evil person. So, when I approach such roles, I look for the person in it. I focus on his reasons and actions and then I try to add more layers to the character,” he said.

Also, for the multifaceted actor, the length of the role has never been a concern.

“It’s a director’s choice. If I like the script, I become a part of the film. Also, there are a lot of reasons we do work... to run our family. Everyone wants to do a big role, but you might not always get that. I look for my happiness in my role,” he said.

Glance through his ‘Instagram’ feed and you would notice his updates on various plays he keeps doing despite his busy schedule as a Bollywood actor. In fact, to think, ‘theatre is a necessity’.

Ask him if training in theatre provides longevity to a film actor and he instantly said, “I don’t like to see it that way. I think you do theatre because you need it. I am talking about myself. Theatre is a completely different space for me. Theatre definitely has an effect on your work because it demands a certain discipline and commitment and you need that for any kind of work,” he said.

Mishra is married to talented actor Ayesha Raza and believes in staying rooted. In an industry that is obsessed with visibility and virality, he remains away from the spotlight when it is not necessary.

“I have to work and I find other things unnecessary, like selling yourself on social media. I don’t judge who is doing that, but I never felt the need. I work and then I go into my cave. If your work is good, you will get work. If not, no matter what you do on social media, you won’t be recognised,” smiled the ‘M S Dhoni: The Untold Story’ and ‘Tiger Zinda Hai’ actor.

‘Bollywood has fragile glass egos’

Randeep addressed the long-standing perception of him being ‘arrogant’

Randeep Hooda, known for performances in films like ‘Highway’, ‘Sarbjit’ and ‘Saheb, Biwi Aur Gangster’, addressed the long-standing perception of him being ‘arrogant’ or ‘difficult’ in the film industry. In a recent conversation, the actor reacted to the rumours surrounding his behaviour on film sets, his fallout with filmmaker Ram Gopal Varma and why his blunt personality was often misunderstood in Bollywood.

In a conversation with ‘Zoom TV’, Randeep explained that much of this image may have been shaped by misunderstandings, his straightforward nature and the way people from Haryana naturally communicate. The actor also clarified that, barring a rare exception, he never had disrespectful confrontations with directors over creative differences.

“I don’t think I have had any disrespectful exchange with a director on any creative thing ever, except once when I was doing an anthology film for the ‘Factory’ (Ram Gopal Varma’s production house), where Ramu and I also had a fallout. Apart from that, there hasn’t been,” he said.

The actor admitted, however, that he later realised how quickly stories travel on film sets, especially through assistant directors. “I didn’t realise that the mouthpiece

of the chatter that goes on in movies comes from assistant directors. So when you’re getting ready and something is not right - maybe the look isn’t right or you’re not getting something correct before going to the set - and there’s an assistant director knocking every minute saying, ‘Sir, ready?’ after you’ve already told them to give you five minutes, then obviously the Jat in you comes out,” he said with a laugh.

Hooda clarified the rumours surrounding his behaviour on film sets

Randeep added that while there may have been moments of disagreement with filmmakers, he always respected the director’s process and often tried multiple approaches during scenes.

According to the actor, his reserved nature and unwillingness to socialise extensively within the industry may have also contributed to the rumours around him. “I think it was blown out of proportion. Also, because I was not mixing around with people too much, those Chinese whispers grew beyond their merit. The film industry is full of fragile glass egos and insecurities.”

AGENCIES



TIFF 2026 TO HOLD CHRISTOPHER NOLAN RETROSPECTIVE

The Toronto International Film Festival (TIFF) will screen all 12 films directed by Christopher Nolan as part of a retrospective ahead of the Oscar-winning filmmaker’s upcoming film ‘The Odyssey’.

The retrospective, titled ‘Christopher Nolan: Grand Designs’ at ‘TIFF Lightbox’, will be held from July 8 to August 20, the festival organisers said in a statement. It will feature multiple screenings of Nolan’s complete body of work as a director, with many films projected in 70mm in the venue’s largest and most technically advanced cinema. All screenings will be exclusively on 35mm and 70mm film, reflecting Nolan’s well-



Titled ‘Christopher Nolan: Grand Designs at TIFF Lightbox’, it will be held from July 8 to August 20, the festival organisers said in a statement

known commitment to analogue filmmaking.

Hailed as one of the most influential voices in contemporary cinema, Nolan first came to the festival in 1998 when his debut feature ‘Following’ screened in the ‘Discovery’ section. He

last returned in 2017 for a special IMAX screening of ‘Dunkirk’ to mark IMAX’s 50th anniversary.

“Christopher Nolan is one of the most influential voices in contemporary cinema today, where each new film is a cultural event,” TIFF Chief

Programming Officer Anita Lee said. “These programmes offer audiences of all ages a compelling look at the scale, creativity and innovation that define film today.”

Over the past three decades, Nolan has built one of the most distinctive bodies of work in contemporary Hollywood. From the neo-noir puzzle of ‘Memento’, the mind-bending ‘Inception’, to the sweeping war epic ‘Dunkirk’ and the science fiction odyssey ‘Interstellar’, his films have not only performed exceptionally well at the worldwide box office but also earned praise from the critics for their narratives and structural complexity and large-format cinematography.

PTI



‘People judged me for not speaking English’

Pankaj Tripathi is regarded as one of the finest actors in the country, but there was a time when success was a distant dream for him. In pursuit of that dream, he came to Delhi to study at the National School of Drama. What he believed would be the beginning of his journey soon turned into a struggle about identity, language and acceptance. In a recent interview, the actor recalled experiencing a massive cultural shock when he first moved to Delhi in 2001.

“When I came to Delhi in 2001, I faced cultural shock. It was the first time I saw girls smoking. I was like, ‘Yeh kaisi ladkiyan hain?’ (What kind of girls are they?) But after about fifteen days, I realised that wasn’t the right way to look at it,” he shared on the ‘YouTube’ channel ‘Yuva’. Coming from a Hindi-medium background, Pankaj

Pankaj Tripathi is regarded as one of the finest actors in the country

revealed that language became one of the first barriers he faced in the city.

He added, “People judged me very quickly because of my language. They assumed that if someone can’t speak English fluently, they must come from a poor background or lack exposure. People often judge your capability based on the language you speak, whereas in reality, the two have nothing to do with each other.”

The actor admitted that such experiences could easily make someone develop an inferiority complex, but he consciously chose not to let it affect his self-worth.

AGENCIES

‘Alia Bhatt is the most sincere actor I’ve worked with’

Bobby Deol shared new details about the action-packed world of ‘Alpha’



with Alia, I have done ‘Alpha’. I had the best time working with both of them.”

Bobby called ‘Alpha’ film ‘new and refreshing’ as it puts two women in the middle of the action. “It is quite amazing that we are making an action film in India, like ‘Alpha’, featuring two girls doing action on screen. I like ‘Alpha’ a lot because it is new, refreshing and a new visual for the audience to watch in theatres,” he said.

Talking about Alpha’s action sequences, Bobby called it ‘raw and real’ and said, “Adi (producer Aditya Chopra) and the director Shiv Rawail had a clear vision that action should look real and raw. So, it was a tough shoot for both of us and I’m glad we have a film that everyone should sit back, relax and hopefully enjoy thoroughly.”

“Alia is one of the hardest-working and most sincere actors I’ve worked with,” he said. AGENCIES



The ‘YRF Spy Universe’ project marks Bobby’s first collaboration with Alia Bhatt